

SAFE WORD

CHEAT CODES III



he lived to forget. now he's dying to remember.

PAUL GARLAND

Safe Word: Cheat Codes III

An Erotic Hotpast Thriller

Paul Garland



Cerulean Erotica

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Foreword

Writing *Cheat Codes: Safe Words* was the most challenging and exhilarating project I've ever taken on. This series asked me to dig deeper than I expected—not just into the mechanics of memory, desire, and betrayal, but into what it means to want to forget, and what it costs to remember. From the first scenes of suburban longing and digital secrets, these characters insisted on being real, flawed, and brave in ways that sometimes surprised even me.

Thank you for coming along for this wild, emotional ride. If this book finds you—whether you're an old reader of mine or a new reader drawn in by the science-fiction aspect of this series—I hope you find echoes of your own questions, heartbreaks, and hopes in these pages. Here's to the courage it takes to confront the past, and the possibility always waiting in the stories we choose to tell next.

With deep gratitude,

Paul

Chapter One

Chapter 1

The car was already waiting, idling at the curb with a polite chime and its indicator blinking slowly in the morning light. Rachel walked a step ahead of me, sharp boots light on the pavement, one hand tugging her tan trench coat belt tight at her waist. Her red hair—glossy and coiled at the nape of her neck—gleamed copper in the sun, not a strand out of place. She looked like she always did when she was headed to work: polished, unreadable, completely in control. Her lipstick matched her mood—subtle and yet effective.

Behind us, Ashleigh stood in the doorway of the house, arms folded loosely, her grey jumper flecked with lint. She was our cleaner—well, residential assistant, if you went by the billing—but she felt like part of the furniture now, always around when needed. Dyed platinum-blond hair pulled into a messy bun that needed the roots touching up, and dark circles under her eyes that seemed less like fatigue and more like a permanent feature. She watched us leave without much interest, as if it was just another Tuesday.

“Thanks, Ash,” Rachel called back. “Don’t forget the bathroom grout if you have time today.”

Ashleigh gave a slight nod. “Got it,” she said softly, her voice quiet and low like always. Barely there.

We got into the car—Rachel’s high-end, silent-glide AIs with no visible driver controls unless you pulled them out manually. Rachel tapped in the destination—Nash Ventures HQ—and the override wheel slid out and flicked slightly as it prepped to drive. I didn’t even think about it, just reached for the wheel out of habit, fingers floating close but not quite touching.

“You don’t need to do that,” Rachel said, glancing at me briefly.

“I know,” I muttered, still not pulling away.

She leaned over and gently placed her hand over mine. “It’s been two years, Paul. You’re okay. You can trust the AI.”

I gave a slight nod but didn't answer. The thing was, I *was* okay. Physically, at least. The crash had been bad—an autonomous systems failure in D.C., a last-second detour around stalled traffic that ended with my car flipped on its side, crumpled against a barrier. I remembered flashes. The sound of shattering glass. The feel of something warm and wet in my hair. Then the hospital. Weeks of it, treatment for my head injury. And after that... We left D.C. and moved to Boston.

We pulled into the garage beneath Nash's glass-wrapped tower, the car easing to a gentle stop. Rachel gave her coat a final tug, glanced at her guru-watch, and said, "I've got Victoria first thing—try not to make me look bad."

"Wouldn't dream of it," I said, and followed her out.

Upstairs, the Nash Ventures office buzzed with clean, curated energy. It was the kind of space where every desk plant looked selected by algorithm and even the coffee tasted like ambition. I said 'Hi,' to my colleagues as we passed, Harry first, standing by one of the shared consoles near our team zone, his dark hair pushed back like it had been fought with and lost. I didn't know him well but he seemed like a good guy. There was a sharpness to him—eyebrows permanently knit, shoulders always just shy of relaxed. He looked up, gave me a curt nod. Friendly enough.

A few desks down, another colleague, Adam was chatting with someone from marketing, leaning against the counter with that casual, slouched confidence. Soft scruff on his jaw, sandy hair with a perpetual I-don't-care tousle, and a smile like he knew things he wasn't telling you. We'd swapped jokes in a Slack thread once, talked in the coffee queue but that was as much as we'd gotten to know each other.

They were both new—like me. All three of us had started within a week of each other, part of some reshuffle tied to the new project teams Rachel had been asked to oversee. But beyond brief greetings, we hadn't really clicked yet, still somewhere in that awkward middle ground between workmates and strangers.

I didn't mind. After the last few years, clean slates had their appeal. My last job had been forgettable—some fintech startup doing mobile payment crap that couldn't decide if it wanted to be a bank or an app. Nash was different. Bigger. More ambitious. Here, I felt like I was finally doing something that mattered. And Rachel was my boss. Which, for now, suited me just fine. I got to work with the woman I loved.

We parted ways as we reached my desk, where I dropped into the chair, powered up my terminal, and tried to find my rhythm for the morning. Across the open-plan floor, Rachel continued, heading towards Victoria Nash—CEO, legend, and probably the most intimidating person I'd ever shared an elevator with. Tall, commanding, always in some variation of high-contrast black or charcoal grey. Today was no different.

Rachel laughed at something Victoria said as they met, a hand brushing the older woman's arm lightly—barely there, but intimate in that familiar, rehearsed way that said they knew each other better than most. Not just boss and rising star. There was an ease between them, the kind you couldn't fake. Rachel had told me once she'd worked at Nash for years, long before Boston. I'd assumed that meant mutual respect between them, but watching them now, I wondered if there wasn't more to it. They were clearly friends.

Rachel turned, caught me looking, and raised an eyebrow before offering a quick smile. She waved and winked, reassuring me that everything was fine, then the two of them headed through the door, into the boardroom.

Around midday, she appeared at my desk with a takeaway cup in each hand and that expression she wore when she was juggling too many things at once and pretending she wasn't. She handed me one of the cups.

"Triple-shot. You looked like you were about to code your way into a coma."

I took it gratefully. "You know me too well. Thanks. How did the meeting go?"

"Great. She just wanted an update on the Living History app. And to check how the new employees are doing." She gave me a wink, then leaned a little closer, her voice lowering. "I told her you're doing acceptably well."

"Acceptably well?" I raised an eyebrow. "You've got me single-handedly coding you an app UI which is going to—"

"Relax," she giggled, pushing a strand of red hair behind her ear, a gesture which always made me appreciate how pretty such was. "I'm joking. Right, I'm going to leave you to it. Oh —before I forget, don't make any plans for tomorrow."

I blinked. "Tomorrow?"

She rolled her eyes. "Your birthday, dumbass. Or did your brain dump that with the crash too?"

I laughed. "I genuinely forgot."

“Which is exactly why I’ve taken care of it. Dinner. Just us. Maybe drinks after. You’ll like it.”

“Where?”

“It’s a surprise.” She stood back, smoothed her skirt. “And remember, I’m seeing my brother tonight for dinner.”

“I’d forgotten that too,” I shrugged. She had told me but it had slipped my mind. “I guess I can do a few things around the house. Those bathroom tiles need fixing.”

Rachel left me to it and the rest of the day passed normally, with me making some headway on the Living History code. The ride home was quiet in that comfortable, end-of-day way. Rachel scrolled through her work messages while I let my mind drift, the AI handling traffic without incident. We didn’t talk much, but we didn’t need to. I was still thinking about a couple of breakthroughs I’d made, lines of code half-forming in my head like unfinished sentences. Outside, the sky was turning that dull, silver-pink shade Boston wore before it got dark again, and the clouds looked heavy with more rain.

When we got home, Rachel was in a rush to get ready to go out, heading straight into the shower while I kicked my shoes off and turned the heating on. It was early Spring but the weather didn’t show any signs of warming up yet.

“Oh, my God” I heard Rachel exclaim, and out of curiosity, I headed upstairs to see what was up.

The loose bathroom tiles had been reset, sealed neatly with fresh grout, and the faint scent of adhesive still hung in the air. Ashleigh was just finishing up, slipping her supplies into the hall cupboard.

“You fixed the tiles?” Rachel asked her as I admired her handiwork.

The cleaner turned, straightening up, closing the cupboard behind her. “Yeah. I got the grout and thought I may as well do it while I had some spare time.”

I gave a small laugh. “You know that’s not technically in your job description, right?”

Ashleigh shrugged, adjusting a stray piece of blonde hair back into the ponytail that it had slipped out of. “I’m handy like that.”

That made me smile, and I wasn’t sure why. Maybe it was the way she said it—flat, casual, like she wasn’t trying to impress anyone. Or maybe it was just how she handled herself. Quietly. Without fuss.

“I appreciate it,” Rachel thanked her, then headed into the shower, a clean towel draped over one arm. “Sorry, I’m in a rush because I’m going out but we’ll see you Thursday?”

Ashleigh nodded. “Yep. I’m heading home now anyway. Have a good night.”

I followed her downstairs, thanking her again before she left and then I grabbed my laptop, finishing a few tasks I’d left undone at work until Rachel came downstairs, looking gorgeous in a smart red blouse and black jeans. Standing in front of the hallway mirror, she checked her crimson lipstick and slipped her coat over her shoulders. “Jean-Marc will be here any second. We’re just grabbing a drink and catching up while he’s in town, nothing crazy. I’ll be back in a couple of hours.”

“You better be,” I teased. “I don’t want to have to kick your ass at work tomorrow for being hungover.”

“Exactly.” She grinned at me through the mirror, then gave her reflection a satisfied look and turned to me. “Oh—there’s dinner in the fridge. Leftover risotto.”

I opened my arms a little. “You’re just too good to me.”

She rolled her eyes and kissed me, quick and sweet. “I know, I know. You’re getting the real celebration tomorrow, don’t forget.”

A knock on the front door interrupted us. Rachel opened it, and Jean-Marc stepped inside like he owned the place.

He looked sharp, as always—black overcoat, dark button-up, tailored to perfection. He was considerably older than Rachel, a twelve year gap between them, and they didn’t look particularly alike, explained by them having the same mother but different fathers, apparently. His salt-and-pepper hair made him look older than he was, but his athletic frame and the way he carried himself—with a kind of easy charm—made people look past his age.

“Paul,” he said, pushing his wire-rimmed glasses higher up the bridge of his nose before smiling as he reached to shake my hand. “Happy almost-birthday.”

“Thanks,” I said. “It’s good to see you.”

“You don’t mind if I steal your wife for a bit, do you?” he asked, flashing me that effortless grin.

I smiled. “She promised to be back in a couple of hours, so I’ll allow it.”

Rachel rolled her eyes and pulled the door closed behind them. “Make sure you eat. I love you,” she said, as they disappeared into the night.

I grabbed the risotto, threw it in the microwave, and dropped onto the couch with a beer. I quite liked it when Rachel went out, which she did a couple of times a week. The place felt quieter—not in a bad way, just... settled. I flicked on the TV, finding a nice easy game show to watch. One where the answers were simple enough to make me feel smart, although I wasn’t even watching properly tonight, just letting the flickering light blur in the background.

The microwave dinged a few minutes later. I stood to grab my bowl, but just as I rounded the kitchen island, I heard the door.

Not the front door—the side one, near the garage.

“Did you forget your keys?” I called, expecting Rachel’s voice.

But it wasn’t Rachel.

Ashleigh closed the door gently behind her, her movements quiet, like she didn’t want the house to notice she was there. She didn’t look at me right away—just glanced around the entryway, her eyes briefly scanning the floor, the kitchen, the soft flicker of the TV across the room.

“I saw Rachel leave,” she said finally. “Sorry to come back in. I just... I wanted to talk to you.”

I blinked, halfway to the microwave. “Okay... is everything alright?”

She nodded, then shrugged. “Yeah. It’s fine. Just... this conversation has been a while coming.”

I turned fully toward her, the risotto temporarily forgotten. “Is something wrong? I mean, with the job? If so, you should speak to Rachel. She kind of makes all the decisions. This is her place, by rights.”

“It’s not,” she said quickly. “It’s not about the job.”

She shifted her bag on her shoulder, like the weight of it was starting to drag her down. Her eyes flicked toward the hall, then back to me. “I’ve been waiting. Trying to figure out the right moment. I was hoping you’d... I don’t know. That you’d remember, in your own time. But... we’ve run out of time.”

“Time for what?”

“For this.” She reached into her bag and pulled out a small black SSD. She held it out, but didn’t move any closer. “You need to hide this. Somewhere safe. Somewhere Rachel won’t look. Somewhere she’ll never find it.”

I didn't take it. "What the hell is that?"

"It's the information from a laptop," she said. "Your laptop. Or one given to you, before things went sideways. I thought it'd be easier for you to hide this though, rather than the actual laptop itself."

I stared at her. "What do you mean, before things went sideways? Are you referring to the crash?"

"There was no crash, Paul." Ashleigh's eyes bored into mine. What was she talking about?

"Um, there definitely was. Ashleigh, are you okay? I don't understand what's going on here."

"Okay. There *was* a crash, but you weren't in it." She looked down at the floor, lips pressing together tightly. When she looked up again, her eyes were shinier than before. I used to clean for you. Before Rachel. Before Boston. Before the crash."

"Back In D.C.?" I asked, already feeling the thrum of my pulse quickening for some reason.

She shook her head. "At your apartment in New York."

"I've never lived in New York."

"Yes, you have," she said softly.

I was quiet for a long beat. The air in the room felt thinner now. The risotto in the microwave was probably cold now. "Ashleigh, I think you have me mixed up with someone else. Either way, I think you should leave."

She stepped forward and placed the drive on the counter, her hands lingering on it like it might vanish if she let go too soon. "Don't look at it while she's home. Don't let her find it. If she does..." She looked up at me, her voice trembling. "You'll put me in danger. Us. You'll put *us* in danger. In fact, you already are."

"Danger?" I shook my head. "Ashleigh, what the hell is on this drive?"

"Memories," she whispered. "Yours. Others'. Stuff that was never supposed to be seen."

I took a breath, but it didn't feel like enough. My chest was tight. "Okay. Keep talking. Explain."

"When I cleaned for you in New York," she went on, "My name wasn't Ashleigh. It was Haley."

The name hit me like a word I'd heard in a dream once—familiar but unreachable. I stared at her, heart suddenly drumming faster.

“That’s not my real name,” she said, and a tear slid down her cheek.
I couldn’t speak. Just watched her.
She looked me dead in the eye.
“My real name...” She paused. “Is Annmarie.”

Chapter Two

Chapter 2

“My real name... is Annmarie.”

The moment the name left her lips, something inside me snapped tight and recoiled like a spring. A sharp pressure clamped down behind my eyes — then a sudden, blinding spike of pain lanced through the base of my skull, hot and electric and instant. My fingers opened reflexively, and the SSD slipped from my hand, clattering to the floor with a hollow, plasticky knock.

The room blurred at the edges, almost taking my balance with it.

In its place came something else — an image, vivid and wrong, like a hallucination projected across the inside of my eyelids. Warm light. Bare skin. A woman’s voice laughing in my ear. Her nails on my chest. Her thighs tightening around my waist. A name whispered like it belonged to me. Like *I* belonged to her.

“I love you,” she whispered in my ear. Her face was blurred as we kissed. I felt something. Something I hadn’t felt in years.

Love.

Not the love I felt for Rachel. Compared to how I felt right now, my feelings for Rachel were... pale. A shadow. Shallow.

The woman stepped back, and as her warmth left me, I felt a void. No. What was happening? I couldn’t lose this.

The world turned white.

Then cold.

And pain. Not just physically but emotionally.

I grabbed the counter with one hand, squeezing my eyes shut until the wave passed. It only lasted a few seconds, but it hollowed me out like nothing I’d felt before. Slowly, I opened my eyes to find her staring at me — not Ashleigh. Not even Haley.

Annmarie.

“Paul,” she said gently, voice trembling. “Are you okay?”

And then it was gone as quickly as it’d arrived. She was Ashleigh again.

“What the hell was that?” I asked, breath catching in my throat. “Did you... Did you do something to me?”

“No,” she said quickly. “But maybe something broke through. Something real. It happens. Nadia warned me. The second wipe causes issues. Sometimes when a name lands, or a place, or a voice...”

I bent and picked up the drive, hands still shaking, heart hammering behind my ribs. “What is this? What’s *on* this thing?”

She swallowed hard. “Memories, journals, videos. Traces of who you used to be. Things they didn’t want you to leave behind. I couldn’t unlock them — I don’t know the passwords. I was hoping that if you saw them, maybe something would click. And I think they were clicking... until they found out.”

“What? What are you talking about? You expect me to hide this?” I asked, holding it up like it might burn through my palm. “From Rachel? Why? She might be able to help me if what you’re saying is true.”

“Absolutely not,” she said, without hesitation. “If she knows... I don’t know what she’ll do, Paul.”

“I’m not hiding things from her. No, I’m not doing that.” I dropped the drive on the island beside my keys. “She’s everything to me. If this is serious, if you’re telling the truth, then she needs to know. I’m going to tell her. Hell, I might call her now.”

“No,” Ashleigh said, too fast. She stepped closer, panic slipping into her voice. “Don’t tell her. Don’t show her that drive. Please, Paul. I’m begging you.”

“Why not?” I demanded. “You realise how crazy all of this sounds, right?”

“Because she’s not who you think she is. And if she sees that drive, if she finds out I came here, she’ll report it to Elysium. She’ll wipe you again. One more reset, Paul... you might not come back from it. You’ll lose *everything*.”

I stared at her, the kitchen suddenly unfamiliar, too bright, too quiet.

“I’ve waited years for this conversation,” she said, eyes shining. “Three years. I kept the files safe until I found you in New York. Until I figured that putting the files on your PC was the best idea. I’ve watched you walk past me every week like I was nobody. I’ve stayed silent. Waiting for you to remember me. To remember *us*. Then I lost you again, for a second time. So

this time, I'm not waiting. I saw the window closing, and I had to do something. Or risk regretting it forever."

"I'm going to call Rachel." I shook my head. "I don't know what you did to me, but I don't like it. If I call her, she'll come home. You can tell all of this to her face. If you're telling the truth, she'll have an answer. I know she will."

Ashleigh didn't move when I reached for my phone. She just stood there, eyes shining with sadness, her face set like she knew this was her only shot. Her voice was steady, but her hands were shaking as she clasped them together in front of her.

"Okay, I'll go, but let me tell you this: there was no crash, Paul."

I froze. "What?"

"No accident. No AI malfunction. They faked it. Programmed your car to crash. But you weren't even in it."

My hand dropped to my side. "That's bullshit."

"It happened in New York. Not D.C. You'd been living there for a couple of years. You were working with Rachel, but you two weren't together. You had a different girlfriend. Watching you with her nearly killed me, but you were happy. I didn't know what to do. Selfishly, I wanted it to fail but at the same time... Seeing you happy made me happy too."

"A girlfriend? New York?" I stared at her. "We were living in D.C. before we came here, Rachel and me."

"No," she said quietly. "That's the narrative they programmed you with. After the second wipe."

"Wipe?" My skin went cold. "What do you mean by wipe?"

She stepped closer. "I'm trying to tell you, but you're not listening. They wiped you, Paul. Your memories. Twice. Me, Claire, Harry, everything back in D.C. Then, again in New York. The crash was a cover to get you into a private facility — drugged, sedated — while the procedure settled. You were unconscious for weeks. When you woke up, they fed you a new life, a new story, a new version of who you were supposed to be."

"No." My voice cracked. I should have dismissed this all out of hand. It was ridiculous, and yet, for some reason, I didn't. "That's not possible."

"They told your coworkers you'd moved. Told your friends you'd left for health reasons. Sent text messages to your girlfriend, Sam, as if they were from you. Told her that it was over, that you were moving to Boston with someone else. She believed it. She had no choice."

My stomach turned. *Sam*. Why did that name make me feel strange? “Sam? What do you mean she had no choice?”

“Your relationship was on the rocks. That made it easier. Cleaner. But you didn’t break up with her. You didn’t *choose* Rachel. She chose you. She stole you.”

I backed up a step, the kitchen island pressing into my spine. “Stop.”

“She orchestrated all of it. The hospital. The narrative. The new job. Do you think you applied to Nash Ventures? No. They *placed* you there. Just like they placed you at TechSphere before that.”

My head began to ache. That cold feeling at the base of my skull again. What was happening to me?

“No. No, you don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“I do.” Her voice cracked now. “And the proof is on that drive. Please, Paul. Trust me.”

I picked it up from the counter and looked down at it in my hand like it might bite me.

“All your memories,” she whispered. “Journals from a woman called Claire. Videos. You’re in them. Photographs. Your real past. Everything they tried to erase. It’s all on there.”

Something twisted deep inside me. My knees almost buckled. Somehow, I knew she wasn’t lying, but she had to be. This was impossible.

“You’re lying,” I said, but it didn’t even sound like me.

“I’m not.”

My head was pounding. Sharp, rhythmic stabs behind my temples, like something inside me was trying to get out. That pain again, that coldness, travelling down my spine.

“I need you to leave,” I said quietly. “Now.”

She opened her mouth, closed it again, then nodded. “Please look at the drive. Everything is in a folder labelled ‘Cheat Codes.’ It was all on a laptop that you hid, right before they took you. Fortunately, I saw you hide it and managed to retrieve it before they cleared out your old apartment.”

“Just go.”

Ashleigh stared at me for a long moment, then nodded, turned and walked out without another word.

The second the door closed, I stumbled toward the hallway, bracing against the wall. The lights blurred. My pulse was a roar in my ears. I barely

made it to the bedroom before my legs gave out. The pain and the strange disorientation I was feeling was worsening by the moment.

I collapsed onto the bed, clothes still on, the drive still clutched in one hand like a relic I couldn't let go of until I hit the sheets, and then it slipped from my hand, disappearing into the darkness.

My last thought before everything went dark was that something had already begun breaking. And it wasn't going to stop.

My head was heavy, thick with sleep I didn't remember falling into. My mouth was dry, my tongue sticking to the roof of it like I'd spent the night talking or crying or grinding my teeth. Maybe all three.

I didn't even register the weight on the mattress until Rachel leaned over me, her voice soft, teasing.

"Happy birthday, sleepy head."

I blinked up at her. Her fiery hair was pulled back in a loose ponytail, no makeup yet, still in her dressing gown. She looked beautiful when she was clean-faced, natural, like she was this morning. Girlish, even. In one hand, she held a tray: scrambled eggs, coffee, toast, and a little glass of fresh orange juice.

"Do you feel any better?" She smiled, concern in her eyes. "I made breakfast, so I hope so."

"What time is it?" I croaked.

"Nearly nine. I let you sleep in." She set the tray across my lap and kissed my forehead. "You were out of it last night. I was honestly a little worried."

I tried to sit up straighter. My body felt leaden.

"You were lying on the bed when I got home," she continued, sitting beside me. "Fully dressed, burning up. You looked fine, but you felt feverish. I thought maybe you were coming down with something."

I swallowed hard. "I don't... I don't remember that."

"You don't remember the soup I made? Or the hot tea?" She raised an eyebrow. "You actually drank tea. Voluntarily. That's how I knew something was wrong."

I gave a weak smile, but my mind was already spinning. Last night was a blank. I remembered coming home from work. The cleaner... Ashleigh. She came back. She wanted to talk to me.

But that was all I could remember. Why did my head hurt so much?

“Did I say anything?” I asked, trying to keep my voice even. “What was up with me? Because I don’t recall anything.”

“You mumbled a bit. I think you said you were tired, that you shouldn’t be here, some other mumbo-jumbo, but I chalked that up to the fever.”

My throat tightened.

“I shouldn’t be here?” I asked. “What does that mean?”

She shrugged. “I don’t know.” She squeezed my knee. “I figured you just needed rest. You seem better this morning.”

I nodded slowly, watching her rise.

“I’ve got your gift in the living room,” she said, tying her robe, giving me an inviting flash of her soft, smooth thighs for a moment. “Don’t go anywhere.”

She left the room, and I was alone again. The tray steamed in front of me, but the smell of eggs turned my stomach. I sat there, breathing through it, trying to calm the thud of my pulse in my ears.

The memory of last night came back in jagged fragments. I recalled her — Ashleigh, no — Haley. No — *Annmarie* — that name rang in my head. Then the pain. The flashback. The drive.

The drive.

I glanced around the room, sudden panic tightening my chest. Where had it gone?

The counter was empty. The dresser, the floor — nothing.

But then, just as I set the tray aside, my eyes caught a glint of black plastic beneath the dresser. Half-tucked in shadow, just visible from this angle.

The SSD.

It must have slipped from my hand when I collapsed.

I reached down, arm stretched under the dresser, fingers brushing the edge, but just as I curled my hand around it, I heard her footsteps returning, and I quickly pulled my hand back as though I’d burned my fingers on something.

Rachel appeared in the doorway, holding a slim silver box with a red ribbon around it. “You’ve not eaten your breakfast,” she said, smiling as she came toward me. “Don’t make me spoon-feed you.”

I sat on the bed quickly and shifted the tray in my lap. “I was just — “ I cleared my throat, forcing a smile. “Stretching.”

“Well, stretch later. Open this first.”

She climbed back onto the bed beside me, the mattress dipping beneath her weight. She set the box on the tray, angled just right, then leaned in to kiss my cheek. “Happy birthday.”

I managed a smile, but my thoughts were still caught on the small square of black plastic beneath the dresser. Still there. Still waiting.

Rachel watched me open the box, her chin on her hand. Inside was a sleek, charcoal-grey guru-watch — beautifully minimalist, the latest in the range with all the latest biometrics and neurolinks. Expensive. Very expensive.

“Jesus, Rach,” I said, holding it up, admiring the diamonds around the face. “This is... a lot.”

“You deserve the best,” she said simply. “It syncs to your work profiles, reads your sleep patterns, does that heart-rate stress scan you keep forgetting to do, reads and reacts to your emotions. Plus, it looks hot. Especially on you.”

I kissed her cheek. “Thank you.”

“Finish your eggs,” she said, already pulling the tray slightly closer to keep me on track. “You’ll need your energy.”

I raised an eyebrow. “For what?”

She grinned. “I’ve booked the day off. As have you. Although you didn’t know you had.”

“I did wonder,” I smiled. “Seeing as you let me lie in until this time.”

“And I cleared your schedule.” She nudged me with her knee. “So when you’re done eating, go shower. Dress nice but comfortable. No suits, no joggers. Something in between. I’ve got plans for today, so don’t keep me waiting.”

“Plans?” I gave her a cautious smile. “Should I be worried?”

“Only if you hate seafood, sunshine, and sex.”

I choked on a mouthful of coffee, and she laughed, already standing.

“You’ve got twenty minutes,” she called over her shoulder as she left the room. “If you’re late, I’m taking sex off the itinerary.”

I looked at the SSD, calling out to me from beneath the dresser. She didn’t know about it. What was I to do? Whatever I decided, I only had twenty minutes to decide. I ate the eggs, forcing them down, despite my stomach reminding me that I wasn’t really hungry.

Then I stood, poking the SSD further beneath the dresser with my toe. It could wait. I didn't have to make a decision right now. Rachel had plans. It was my birthday. Ashleigh — Annmarie, whoever she was, wasn't important right now. I needed to clear my head so I could think straight.

The drive out to Rockport took just over an hour, skimming the coastline as the morning haze lifted off the water. Rachel drove this time, which surprised me — she usually let the AI handle everything — but she said she liked the winding turns up here, the way the roads curled through sleepy clapboard towns and pine-covered hills. It felt like something from a postcard. Rows of white-trimmed houses with porches, a strip of candy stores and souvenir shops, the harbour speckled with fishing boats bobbing lazily in the sunlight. Everything moved slower here. Even the air felt different — a salt tang, refreshing, like a long, cool drink.

We parked just off the main strip and walked hand-in-hand toward the beach, grabbing coffees and walking along the boardwalk. Rachel kept up a light stream of conversation — jokes, little observations, teasing comments about the tourists who dressed like it was a summer vacation when the spring breeze off the water was still stiff enough to sting your face and make your eyes water. We passed a woman in a wool coat carrying a lobster roll the size of her head, and Rachel squeezed my hand, eyes sparkling. “That’s going to end in disaster,” she whispered. “Five bucks says the seagulls mug her.”

I laughed. It felt easy. Natural. It was the first time all morning that I wasn't thinking about the SSD or the way my heart thumped in my chest when I'd kicked it further under the dresser. Rachel had gone to so much trouble today. The birthday breakfast, the choice of where to visit, the drive, the hotel she'd booked for overnight — she was trying. I could feel it. Whatever else might be going on, whatever strange pulse of wrongness had wormed its way into my gut, she was doing this for me. That must mean something.

And yet, some part of me kept glancing sideways at her, like I was waiting for the mask to slip. What had Ashleigh done to me?

We walked along the beach after lunch, shoes in our hands, the sand cool underfoot. She leaned into me when the wind picked up, her arm looped

through mine, and we talked about random nothings for a while. Vacation houses and how much they cost. Future places we could visit. We found some sea glass. Saw a crab that looked like it was flipping us off. We took photos near the rocks and kissed in front of the lighthouse. The smell of the sea air, the warmth of her mouth on mine, the sound of seagulls and laughter around us. This was real. Ashleigh was wrong. Nothing but a crazy woman.

And yet — somewhere beneath the perfection of the day, something was off. A tiny, persistent ache, like a misaligned note in an otherwise harmonious melody. It wasn't even that I didn't trust Rachel. I know I loved her. She loved me. This proved it. Or did it prove it *a little too much*?

I thought about Annmarie — no, *Ashleigh* — about the sincere look in her eyes. The desperation in her voice. I thought about the image that had seared itself into my brain the moment she said her name. About the way my body had remembered something my mind couldn't. I should tell Rachel. I should show her the drive. Ask her if any of it was true. But what would that do to this moment? What if it really was nothing? What if Ashleigh was deluded, mad, a crazed stalker or a woman with some other weird agenda? What if telling Rachel right now shattered her happiness?

I glanced over at her, watching her tuck her hair behind her ear as she looked out at the water. She looked so content. So proud of herself. And I didn't want to ruin it.

Not today.

The Cerulean Rockport Hotel sat at the edge of the coast, just beyond the town's clustered shops and winding lanes. Sleek and glass-wrapped, it stood out like something imported from the future. It didn't belong here, not really, but you couldn't stop progress. Cerulean were building hotels everywhere, offering their five-star service in new places all the time.

Rachel had clearly pulled strings — our room was one of the premier suites on the top floor, facing the sea. Inside, everything was brushed steel and warm wood, mood lighting and their signature citrus scent. The windows ran from floor to ceiling, the ocean an endless shimmer just beyond the glass. A wide bed topped it all off, with pristine ivory linen and charcoal pillows.

I dropped our bags and wandered toward the window while Rachel kicked off her heels and stepped out of her coat. She came up behind me, arms sliding around my waist. “So, how do you rate your birthday planner?”

“Ten out of ten,” I said, covering her hands with mine. “This is...”

“Amazing?”

“Yeah. That.”

She kissed the back of my neck and walked around me, her dress sliding from her shoulders as she did. She must have unzipped it when my back was turned. Just like that — effortlessly sexy — she was in her lingerie. No tease, no slow reveal — just Rachel, confident and smiling in a matching black bra and panty set that was begging to be removed. See-through lace did little to hide her tight, pink nipples and the dipping curve of her pussy.

I reached for her without thinking. She pulled me in by the shirt and kissed me hard, pushing me back toward the bed in one slow, continuous motion. Her mouth was soft but urgent, tongue sliding against mine, her fingers already working the buttons of my shirt open one at a time, slow, methodical.

“You always taste better when I take charge,” she whispered against my lips.

“You like being in charge,” I said, grinning as she kissed me.

She smirked. No answer needed to that.

I sat on the edge of the bed as she pulled off my shirt, then dropped to her knees to undo my belt. Her fingers grazed my bulge as she looked up, eyes half-lidded, lips parted.

“You’re already hard,” she noted softly.

“Are you surprised?” I breathed. “Have you looked in a mirror while wearing that underwear?”

“I’m glad you like it,” she murmured, dragging my trousers down and leaning in to kiss along my thigh. “I want your cock as hard as you get. I want it to hurt when it goes in.”

She took me into her mouth without ceremony, warm and wet and deep. Her rhythm was measured, eager but still slow — but this wasn’t for me, not entirely. It was about control. Hers. And I liked that.

She held my hips still when I tried to move, her nails digging in, and when I gasped, she smiled around my cock. “Stay still,” she instructed me. “Let me give you your birthday gift properly.”

She sucked me for what felt like an age, her tongue gliding up and down my shaft, curling around the head. She deep-throated me without gagging, enjoying the sound of my moans. Bringing me to the edge then stopping, waiting until I'd calmed down before continuing.

When she finally pulled away, she stood and climbed onto the bed, straddling my lap and reached behind her back, undoing her bra, tossing it to the floor. My hands went straight to her breasts, pert and perfectly shaped, my thumbs grazing her nipples until she shuddered. Her pale skin, lightly freckled, glowed in the light of the dying sun outside.

"You're going to fuck me now," she ordered me, "Hard. And rough. As rough as you dare. You have my permission."

That made me pause. Just a second. But something about the way she said it — casual, off-hand, like a joke — made a chill crawl up my spine.

"I don't need permission to fuck my wife-to-be," I said, voice hoarse, shrugging the feeling off.

Her eyes narrowed, almost playful. "Good boy. That's the spirit. But first..."

Her hands tangled in my hair, and she shoved me down, pulling her panties to one side. I knew what she wanted and kissed her there, enjoying her sigh as my lips grazed her clit, already peeking out, wet and glossy.

I tore her panties as I ripped them from her, throwing them over my shoulder, then delved my tongue into her. She'd shaved for the occasion, her mound soft and hairless. Her lips were wet, soft and delicate as I let my mouth roam over them, enjoying the sweet, musky taste of her. Then her hands were in my hair again, pulling almost painfully, dragging me over her.

"Fuck me now."

She reached down, grabbing my throbbing cock and guided me inside her roughly, both of us gasping at the contact. She was hot, tight, already soaked as the tip of my cock drove inside her. She rocked her hips forward at first, letting me feel every inch of her, letting the friction build, then thrust onto me, desperate to be fucked. My hands gripped her hips, her waist, her ass — anything I could hold onto as she started to buck her hips forward with increasing urgency.

"You always feel so fucking good," she whispered. "Like you were made for me."

“Maybe I was,” I moaned, the feeling of her pussy fucking me almost overwhelming.

“Hard,” she groaned, her eyes holding me. “Do me hard, Paul.”

I grabbed her legs, pushing them back against her chest, feeling myself go even deeper.

“That’s it,” she growled. “Do it. Don’t hold back. I need it rough.”

I pulled out as far as I could, then hammered back into her, savouring the way she tossed her head back. Then I repeated the movement, thrusting into her savagely, the sound of our bodies connecting filling the room as I got into a rhythm.

After a while, both of us dripping in sweat, she leaned forward, her mouth near my ear. “You trust me, don’t you?”

“I do,” I said, words escaping before I even thought about them, not even questioning the reason for the oddly timed question.

That part of my brain — the one that should’ve been questioning, parsing, doubting — was gone. Just like before, in the alley, when she’d called out to me. Just like when I told her everything, back in my apartment, the mascara running down her face.

Wait. What alley? What apartment?

“You’re mine,” she whispered, pushing me backwards with surprising force, catching me off guard. She rolled me onto my back, climbed on top of me, sliding her pussy down onto me, her body grinding down hard. “All mine, Paul Lacuna. Mine.”

Her hands framed my face, holding me still as she moved on top of me, her breasts brushing against my chest with every downward thrust of her pussy onto me. My hands slid down her back, feeling the sweat beading along her spine. Her pussy clamped down onto me, her inner walls gripping me, her thighs trembled. Her lips were parted, breath catching and then she came with a stifled moan, face pressed to my neck, hips jerking hard against me until I followed, shooting my cum uncontrollably inside her as I groaned her name.

The alleyway. My apartment. Those memories weren’t mine, but they only floated in my mind for one second then slipped away as I tried to recall them, the aftermath of my orgasm washing them away like the waves lapping on the beach outside.

We lay there for a long moment, holding each other for a long moment, our bodies pressed together, damp, hot, not moving. That’s when I saw it.

A tiny blue flicker in the ceiling above us. Almost hidden behind a clear perspex panel. Blinking rapidly.

I shifted slightly, and Rachel kissed my cheek. “I needed that,” she sighed. “You were good.”

“You too... I just — what’s that?”

She turned her head and glanced lazily upward. “RoomRecall Sensor. Part of the tech I helped develop back in D.C. Cerulean must’ve picked up the licensing.”

“Really? It feels a little... invasive.”

She smiled. “Don’t worry. It’s not filming you. It’s registering heat shifts and movement. Adaptive climate control. Emotional recognition, mood presets and responses. Lighting sync. That kind of thing. They say it creates the perfect stay over time.”

“Right.”

But my skin prickled, like something had been watching us. Recording something more than heat and movement.

Rachel climbed off me, my cum trickling down the inside of her thigh, and padded to the bathroom, tossing a wicked smile over her shoulder. “Round two starts when I’m out of the shower. Unless you need a nap, old man.”

I lay back against the pillows, heart still pounding. I trusted her — I loved her — but for some reason, something didn’t feel right. And I didn’t know why.

The SSD was waiting for me back at home. When we got back, when I had the place to myself, it wouldn’t hurt to look at whatever it was that was on there.

Would it?

Chapter Three

Chapter 3

The house was quiet this morning, save for the sounds of birds singing through the open window. Everything felt so normal. The traffic driving by on the road outside. There wasn't even anything major on the news earlier. Krissy Saffron, the famous rockstar was getting a divorce from her husband, the entrepreneur, Rick Hazzard. It was just an ordinary day.

Except it wasn't.

We'd come back from Rockport first thing, Rachel still glowing from the night spent at the hotel. We'd barely slept. Not for lack of trying, but because every time she touched me — or I touched her — we'd ended up fucking again. On the bed. On the floor. In the shower. Against the window with the ocean in the background, her breath fogging up the glass.

And this morning, before we checked out, it had happened again. Slower, lazier. She'd climbed on top of me and ridden out the last of my birthday trip like she didn't want it to end. I could still smell her on my skin.

It had been a good birthday.

But that was yesterday. I'd managed to push the unnerving things that Asheigh had told me out of my head for a while but now, alone with just the house and the singing birds outside for company, everything our housekeeper had said was back at the forefront of my thoughts.

Rachel had left after lunch. A meeting with Victoria Nash — face-to-face, not a call. "Just coffee," she'd said, brushing her hair up into a twist. "We've got some launch issues to go over, and she wants my read. You relax. Stay horizontal. We don't need you in the office today Call it your birthday recovery day."

She'd kissed me twice before leaving. Smiled like everything was perfect. And to her, it probably was. To me... it wasn't. The moment the door closed, I exhaled. The echo of it seemed to ripple through the house, like the tension had been waiting to exhale too.

I headed upstairs, stood in the middle of the bedroom for a second, then dropped to my knees and reached beneath the dresser.

There it was. The SSD. Cold black plastic against the floorboards. The same one Annmarie — *Ashleigh* — had handed to me just before everything short-circuited in my brain. I hadn't touched it since. Hadn't needed to. Just holding it had done something to me. Or maybe it was her name that had cracked something open. Annmarie. Not Ashleigh. Not Haley.

And not a stranger.

I carried it to the spare room. My PC was still there, humming softly beneath the desk like it had been waiting. I fired it up and slotted in the drive.

A folder appeared. Just one. And two files.

CHEAT_CODES.

The folder and its name tickled something in my mind. Familiarity but elusive, ungraspable.

Then the two files.

FROM_ANNMARIE.TXT

CONNECT.EXE

I opened the text file.

Hello Paul, please read this before you do anything else.

If you're reading this, then a part of you inside wants to know the truth. I wasn't sure it would.

My name is Annmarie. You knew me before you knew Rachel. Before Ashleigh, Haley, Sam. Before all of this.

I'm not asking you to believe everything right away. I'm just asking you to trust that the man you were before is still inside you somewhere.

We weren't perfect. You and I. But it was real. And what they did to you — what they took away — it wasn't right. They did more than you agreed to. They betrayed you.

Inside the folder is everything you need to know, with proof. Know that what you will read in there could be painful. But you should know who you were. Who are you really are. The truth.

When you've seen enough, there's a program with this called "Connect.exe." My friend wrote it. You knew her too, although you won't remember her. Run it. It will connect you to her.

Her name is Nadia.

She's the reason I'm here. And why all of this happened. If anyone can bring you back — it's her.

Please, Paul. Don't tell Rachel. Don't show her this drive. Terrible things will happen, if you do. Trust me. I beg you.

And just... remember...

I love you. I always did. I always will.

That was it. No signature. No date. Just the name.

Annmarie.

I leaned back in the chair, the words burning from the screen into my eyes. I didn't know how to feel — whether I could bring myself to believe her, whether I wanted to. Whatever was in the folder should convince me, or not, but should I even look? Another thought crossed my mind. What if this was an elaborate scam?

I went to a website I often used in the office, a source for web tools and downloaded an extra-strong firewall. Then a sandbox tool, running them both so that I could open all the files in a virtual desktop, securing my PC from any malware that might be hidden away in the folder.

I noticed the folder and its content had once been locked, password protected, but was now unlocked. A single line of text popped up, along with the filled password box.

If you're reading this, you wanted to forget me.

Inside was another text file that echoed the same words in the first file, but this one was signed by 'P & C' rather than Annmarie. Another folder was there, MEMORY_1, which took me to more files. There was a photo of a hotel bedroom, a red dress on the bed. A Cerulean Hotel, judging by the brochure next to the bed and a contract which I couldn't read, no matter how much I zoomed in. More text files, seemingly leaving clues that had already been solved, reiterating that some things were best left forgotten, that I chose to forget these things for a reason. And then, a video.

FIRST_NIGHT.MP4

So far there was no proof that any of this was about me but once I watched it, all of that changed.

A beautiful brunette woman in sexy black lingerie — her face, her voice, both unsettlingly familiar — greeted me through the camera lens before telling me what was happening.

"Paul, I wanted to record this before... well, before everything starts."

She twisted a gold band on her finger — a wedding ring. This felt too real. My throat tightened.

“I love you. I need you to remember that, no matter what happens tonight. This was your idea at first, but now I want it too. I’ve been thinking about it constantly. I’m nervous but excited too. God, I’m so wet just thinking about it.” The lip bite she did while looking directly into the camera seemed so familiar, I was sure that Rachel did that. But this wasn’t her. “About him. About you watching.”

She leaned into the camera, giving me a perfect view of her cleavage as her breasts pushed together. “Thank you for letting me do this. For understanding what I need.” She took her wedding ring off and showed it to the camera. “Still yours. Always yours. But tonight...” She hid the ring beneath one of the pillows. “I’ll record it all and show you the video later, after, when you’re inside me again, reclaiming what’s yours.”

The video ended with a man’s voice saying from off camera, “Hi, Claire.” I stared at the black screen, wishing there was more, then realised there probably was, amongst all the folders and files on the SSD.

I kept looking, until I came upon the journal entries. I read through them, fascinated and weirdly turned on. The woman — Claire — claiming to be my wife, gave me the name of the man in the hotel. Adam. Then went on to describe how she’d fucked him, how good he was. How she continued to fuck him, having sex with him while I watched from a chair in the corner of the room.

A letter to me described it:

“I remember that night so vividly. The nervousness in your eyes as you watched from that chair. The way you reclaimed me afterward with such intensity. We thought we were in control then. We believed we could contain what we’d unleashed.

We were wrong.

You’ve seen the video. You’ve read my words. You know where our marriage led us — to places both exhilarating and dangerous. I won’t apologise for the pleasure we found, but I can’t ignore how things spiralled beyond what either of us intended.”

What the fuck was this? I was one of those... men... who enjoyed watching his wife with other guys? For some reason, my cock stirred in my pants, making me feel uncomfortable but I kept working through the files.

“Part of me hopes you’ll stop here, close this file, and move forward with your life. But another part of me — the selfish part — wants you to remember us.

When you agreed to Fresh Start, you wanted every trace of our life together erased. I respected that choice, but couldn't bear the thought of our story disappearing forever. So I left these breadcrumbs, hidden where only you might someday find them.

Perhaps one day, when enough time has passed, you'll look at what we did differently. Maybe you'll even forgive us both. I miss you, even though by now, if you're reading this, you've forgotten me entirely. Forever yours, Claire."

Fresh Start. Those two words sent an inexplicable shiver down my spine but the next journal entry and video turned my blood to ice. The note told me how I'd been married to Claire and had discovered a folder — this folder — on her computer, hiding journal entries about her cheating on me. I'd confronted her and we'd decided to open our marriage, leading to me watching her fuck other men to satisfy her needs, then joining in, even threesomes with Adam. There was a video, filmed by me, it had my face in shot at several moments, confirming that this was me — a past version of me — and then more journal entries. A guy called Jean-Marc, a friend who I'd brought into the company to work with me later. And Harry, my best friend, who we also had threesomes with.

I stopped when the journal entries wrote about Harry's wife. *Annmarie.*

Annmarie was Harry's wife? That made no sense if she said she loved me.

Wait. Harry. Adam. They were the names of the two guys that I worked with. Who had started the same time as me. They'd seemed oddly familiar, even though I didn't know them.

I watched the video again and looked at Adam's face as he fucked my wife on the hotel bed. *Oh, fuck.* It was him. Adam, from the office. *No fucking way.* I'd been so intent on watching the woman, enjoying the crazy sex I'd had with the two of them, that I hadn't really looked at his face.

But it was him. And me. But we barely knew each other.

I read a couple more journal entries. More sex with Adam, with Harry, a foursome with Claire and Annmarie, with Jean-Marc. Then I came upon an innocuous sounding picture — FISHING.JPEG — which rocked me to the core.



It was me, Annmarie and Harry from work. A slightly younger-looking version of the three of us, but undeniably us. We were standing by the ocean, somewhere beautiful. How was this possible? This — all of it — gave me a weird sense of déjà vu. I couldn't pretend this wasn't real now. It seemed crazy. Beyond crazy. But something in my gut told me I'd seen enough.

I returned to the first folder, leaving folders and files unread, some of them still locked. I didn't have time to figure out the riddles that the older version of me had apparently worked out and solved. I needed answers and I needed them now.

The files said this was real. The video and the photo confirmed it. But the way my hands were shaking as I moved the mouse? That said everything.

I positioned the mouse pointer over the file.

CONNECT.EXE

I double-clicked.

The screen flashed black. A command window blinked open, green lines flickering across it — strings of code I couldn't quite make out. Then the terminal disappeared.

A second later, a grainy video window opened. Static, just for a moment. Then her face appeared.

A hood drawn up over her hair, something blue glowing faintly beneath it. Dusky skin. Sharp features. Her eyes locked on mine the second she saw me.

"Paul," she said quickly, her voice low and controlled. "Don't talk. Just listen. Are you alone?"

I nodded, too fast.

"I'm so glad Annmarie gave you the SSD," she continued. "That you opened it. That you want to know more. However, that means you're in more danger than you realise."

I swallowed. My throat was dry. This was a live call.

"Are you Nadia?" I asked. "Where is Annmarie?"

“Yes,” she said, her voice firm and low, her dark eyes holding mine, making me realise she must be accessing the webcam on the monitor in front of me. “So don’t talk unless I ask you to. I’m close by. I’ve been waiting for this moment. Don’t worry about Annmarie. She’s safe.”

I opened my mouth instinctively, something between a question and a plea already forming, but she cut me off with a gesture — sharp, ready for this. “I’ll explain everything, Paul. But not here. Not like this. You don’t remember me — and that’s expected. It’s okay. My name is Nadia. You and I... we know each other. From before the second wipe. Like you, I used to work at Elysium, but at a different time. I can help.”

She leaned closer to the camera, and again I could see the faint blue glow of something beneath her hood — reflected off her cheekbones, catching the edges of a healed scar on her temple. “Listen. You need to meet me. In person. Now. I’ve been waiting close by, hoping you’d get in contact but we’ve got a short window, and I don’t know when you’ll get another. So, let’s do this now.”

I didn’t speak. I just nodded.

“Out the back of the house,” she said. “Take nothing with you. No phone. No devices. Just the SSD and the clothes on your back. I’ll find you.”

Then she was gone. The screen blinked to black, leaving nothing but my own dim reflection staring back.

For a few seconds, I didn’t move. My legs didn’t work. My hands had gone clammy on the keyboard. Something about the speed of it all — the intimacy of her voice, the urgency in her instructions — had short-circuited any hope of rational thought. But whatever instinct remained kicked in, and I was moving before I even realised it.

I grabbed my sneakers from by the front door, didn’t bother with socks. Slipped into a thin jacket, tucked the SSD deep in the inside pocket, and slid out the side gate into the alley that ran behind our row of houses. The wind bit down as I stepped outside, sharp enough to sting my ears, causing me to pull the jacket’s hood up.

Nadia was waiting near the end of the alleyway, standing beside a silver van with darkened windows. She wore black from head to toe — a zipped-up hoodie, gloves, heavy boots, hood pulled low over her face. A small handheld scanner rested in her gloved hand, and it beeped softly as she raised it toward me when I approached.

“Hey, handsome,” she said with a soft smile. She didn’t sound scared. She sounded focused. “Don’t move. Trust me, okay?”

I stopped before her, heart thudding in my ears, eyes fixed on the scanner as she stepped in close and swept it down one side of my body, then the other. The scanner flashed red.

“Shit,” she murmured under her breath, already reaching into her jacket for something else.

“What?” I asked, my voice barely above a whisper.

“You’re tagged. Multiple active signals.” She pulled out a wand-like device and scanned across my wrist. “The Guru-Watch, for sure. But something else. Probably embedded. Possibly your Hard Core chip.” Her voice dropped lower. “You’re still fully online.”

I looked down at the watch Rachel had given me for my birthday. I hadn’t taken it off since the moment she’d fastened it on my wrist. High-end. Elegant. And now apparently spying on me.

“They’re tracking you,” Nadia said, tapping her scanner against her palm. “I don’t blame them, considering what happened before. Vitals, location, maybe even audio —if we’re unlucky. Rachel’s been monitoring you. Constantly.”

The words sat heavy in my stomach, sour and cold. “She... what?”

“She’s not who you think she is, Paul,” Nadia said, meeting my eyes. “She’s part of all this. Maybe even the mastermind. She put an implant in your head. A device I designed and you refined. It’s called Hard Core.”

I didn’t want to believe her. But after the things I’d just seen, the puzzle pieces didn’t need much forcing to fit.

“Give me the watch,” she said, holding out her hand.

I unclasped it and passed it over. She took it, connected it to a slim device hanging from her belt, and tapped furiously on the screen. “I’m going to ghost the signal. Clone your chip’s signature onto the watch, let it spoof your biometrics. Random movement. Pulse fluctuations. All of it. Then we leave it in the house.”

“You can do that?” I asked, watching her hands work.

She shot me a glance. “You’ll be surprised what I can do. And what you can do, once we have your memories back.”

That answer hit harder than I expected.

“Once it’s spoofed,” she said, “They’ll think you’re still at home. Asleep. Pacing. Going to the bathroom. It’ll buy us a few hours — until Rachel gets

home.”

“And if they find out I’m gone before then?”

Her eyes were deadly serious now. “Then they’ll come for you. For us. And if they catch you and hit the reset protocol again... I won’t be able to save you after that. Now, go. Put the watch somewhere in the house then meet me back here. Then, we’ll discuss what comes next.”

I did as she instructed, heading back home and tossing the watch onto the bed, then exited the house via the same side door, finding Nadia where I’d left her. She turned, opened the back doors of the van, and gestured for me to follow. Inside was a world unto itself. Screens lined the walls, their displays scrolling through lines of code, maps, bio-data streams. A table was bolted to one side, a small coffee maker and a half-eaten protein bar beside an open laptop showing my profile, complete with the red outline of the Guru-Watch flashing steadily.

“Welcome to my mobile lab,” she said. “Get in. We’ve got work to do.”

I climbed inside. The doors shut behind me with a low click. The quiet inside was surprising, like the van itself had been soundproofed.

She sat down at her console, sliding her hood back in one fluid motion, revealing a shock of sleek, violet hair that caught the dim light like strands of silk dipped in ink. It was shaved on one side, where the edge of a small neural implant sat flush against her skin, glowing faintly blue. Her face was striking — angular in the right places, soft in the others. High cheekbones, strong jaw, eyes that felt like they saw too much. She wasn’t trying to be pretty, which only made her more so.

I found myself staring a moment too long, searching for something familiar and not finding it — but feeling like I should. I cleared my throat and said, “I like your hair.”

It came out stupidly flat. Casual in the worst way. Her eyes flicked up to mine, unreadable, and I wished I could drag the words back down my throat. But she only gave a wide grin, like she’d heard me say worse.

“I mean,” I added, floundering now, “the colour. It’s cool. Unique. And the implant thing...”

She nodded once, her eyes twinkling with amusement. “Had to dye it after the run from my last base. Too many cameras watching for me. I went red for a while. Then green. You get good at disappearing when people are looking for your signature look. But now I’m purple again, because... fuck them.”

I gave a tight nod back, not sure how to respond. It didn't matter. She was already turning back to the console, pressing a few keys, and the blinking red on the screen shifted to green. "Done. Your signal's bouncing around the house now like you never left."

I exhaled, only then realising I'd been holding my breath.

"Now," she said, turning to face me, "We can talk. No more lies. No more hiding or dodging around the facts."

I nodded slowly. "I want the truth."

Her gaze didn't waver. "Then let's start with what they did to you. What *you* did to yourself. And why it all started with a program called Fresh Start. Designed by a company called Elysium."

She leaned forward, her hands steepled, her posture disciplined but relaxed — like someone used to balancing pressure with precision. The soft glow from the monitors played across her features, catching the shimmer of her neural implant and the violet of her hair as she studied me.

"I worked there first," she explained, going on to describe how she designed the Hard Core chip, a brain implant that could lock away memories, but how she'd left after realising that Elysium intended to use it for more than that— for what she felt were nefarious intentions. And how they'd reset her to make her forget the very technology she'd created.

"With me gone, they brought you in. You and Harry. You took over as the architects of Fresh Start," she began. "You were the ones who took the core neural reset theory from prototype to execution. The dream was noble, at first. Memory cleansing for trauma survivors. A reset for people on the edge. The reasons why I'd worked on it. It was supposed to help people."

"But it didn't?" I asked, my voice hoarse.

She gave a bitter smile. "Elysium saw potential for weaponisation. Controlled resets. Soft reprogramming. Identity modulation. They took the Hard Core system and turned it into something darker. You started seeing it too late, just like I did. From what I've learned, you tried to sabotage your own code. Harry didn't agree with it. Things went bad between you... and not just because of that, but because of your failing relationships at home. You, Claire, Harry, Annmarie, it had all turned into a mess."

I leaned forward, hands clasped between my knees, trying to wrap my head around the edges of what she was saying. "And that's why I... wiped myself?"

“You requested it,” Nadia said, not unkindly. “You wanted out. Not just because of that but... something you did. Or that you thought you did. You told Claire — your wife — that you didn’t trust what you’d become. Or what Harry was becoming. You asked her to help you forget.”

The name hit me again like a soft bell rung deep in the marrow. Claire. My wife.

“And Rachel?” I asked, swallowing. “Where does she fit into all of this?”

“She worked with you at Elysium. A talented genius neurosurgeon. You had an affair with her too, something she wanted to continue but you didn’t. She put the Hard Core chip inside your brain and then after the reset, she was planted into your life as a stabiliser. At first, just your work colleague. A controller. A handler, technically. Her job was to keep an eye on you. You were a test subject, of sorts. Just like me, Harry, Claire. But when you started pulling at threads again in New York, when you started remembering, with the help of Annmarie’s files and Adam and me, they came for you. Captured you and Adam, ran the protocol on both of you. Harry too. They made it look like an accident, rewrote your pasts, your histories for a second time. Then they brought the three of you here, to Boston, to work on a brand new project.”

I closed my eyes for a moment. It was too much. Too fast. But it made sense in the worst kind of way.

Nadia’s voice softened slightly. “But when I designed Hard Core, I hard-coded a way back. A reversal method. You knew about it. You worked on it, expanded it. I could explain more but it’ll be hard for you to understand. It might be better if we simply tried to — ”

Before she could continue, the back door of the van opened and a gust of cold air swept in.

Annmarie climbed up into the van, her blonde hair tied back, cheeks pink from the wind. She didn’t say anything at first, just gave me a look — one I couldn’t read. Not pity. Not apology. Something more complex. The weight of knowing something I didn’t.

“You came,” she said softly, settling beside Nadia, opposite me. “Thank god.”

I swallowed the knot in my throat. “I don’t even know what I’m doing here. This is all so crazy, but somehow I know it’s true.”

Annmarie reached forward, like she might take my hand, then thought better of it and pulled back. “There’s a lot I want to say,” she murmured.

“Things I want to explain. But honestly... it might be better if you remember on your own. Hearing it won’t make it real. You’ll just fight it.”

I looked between them, my heart thudding. “You two keep saying that. That I won’t understand. Try me.”

“If we told you everything now,” Nadia said, “You’d either shut down or run. It’s too much to take in all at once. Since you and I first worked on this thing, they’ve upgraded the Fresh Start program. I think they’ve now got ways of making your mind reject it, Paul. You’ll think we are the crazy ones. They’ve programmed you to love Rachel. No. The only way through this is memory reactivation. That’s the only way you’ll believe any of it.”

Annmarie nodded. “It’s the only way you’ll remember us.”

“Us?” I asked.

She just looked at me.

Nadia leaned forward, voice lower now. “You left behind a recovery sequence. A reversal programme called the Safe Word Sequence Protocol. Five words. Four of them we’ve already recovered. You remembered them with Harry’s help, right before they captured you in New York.”

She slid the data slate across the small table toward me. On it were four simple words:

Secret. Etch. Chore. Reach.

“We just need the missing word and we think we’ve found it,” Annmarie whispered, staring down at them as I read them.

I saw it instantly — the last two letters of one word formed the first two of the next.

Annmarie pointed to the slate. “That pattern loops. The final word should begin with ‘CH’ and end with ‘SE’. A closed circuit. You and Claire liked these sorts of puzzles. You often left them around the house to test each other.”

We did? My pulse kicked up at the thought of what my past really held. “So what’s the last word?”

“It could be ‘Cheese,’” Nadia said with a slight shrug. “Could be. Or ‘Chase.’ Or any other words that meets the criteria.”

I stared at them both. “And what happens if I get it wrong?”

“You won’t,” Nadia said gently. “You’ll remember it, I’m sure of it. But while you’re going through the various possible words, your system might stall. Your body’s going to react. So I’m giving you a sedative — just

enough to ease the strain while the memories repopulate. Your brain needs to survive the re-upload.”

I hesitated, then nodded once. She pulled another gizmo from a drawer, a shiny, silver device with a long needle. Something tickled at my memories and apprehension filled my veins for a moment. But Nadia didn’t hesitate. She pressed the needle into my arm, a hiss of air, a pinch, and then warmth spreading through my chest and limbs.

Nadia nodded. “Whenever you’re ready.”

“So, I just recite the words?”

“Yes. In that order. Followed by whatever the last word is,” Annmarie replied, her eyes holding mine.

I closed my eyes and breathed in. Then I said the words.

“Secret. Etch. Chore. Reach...”

A pause. My mouth was dry.

“Cheese.”

Nothing. I tried again.

“Chase.”

Still nothing.

I opened my eyes. The two women were watching me, neither moving nor blinking. Then, something shifted in my gut. Somehow, I knew. Somehow, I remembered.

“Secret. Etch. Chore. Reach...” I took another breath. “Choose.”

The van dimmed around me. My skin prickled. Then the world snapped to white.

A crackling, electric pulse tore through my skull. My thoughts fractured, then reassembled into something unfamiliar — faces I didn’t know but had once loved. Voices I hadn’t heard in years echoing from inside me.

Static. Then fragments. Then everything.

Somewhere far away, Annmarie’s voice reached through the rush of noise.

“It’s working. He’s coming back.”

And Nadia’s. “I’ll connect him to the support system. ARIA. Get us out of here. Take us to the New Nest.”

I felt something being attached to me, wires, monitors. I was on the floor. The van lurched into motion.

And I fell into the past.

Chapter Four

Chapter 4

There was nothing. No light. No air. No direction.

Just me, suspended in a void that had no shape, no colour — only a weightless silence so absolute it felt like the world had ended. I didn't know if I was lying down or standing up. Didn't know if I had a body at all. I only knew I was here. I only knew *I was*.

Then — movement.

A shimmer. A flicker in the corner of my unseeing eye. Another figure, born from the black like smoke given form. He walked toward me with no sound, no footfalls, until he was close enough for me to see —

Me.

His hair was longer. A little messy. There was a city-worn sharpness in his clothes — charcoal jeans, a navy coat, a collared shirt half-unbuttoned like he'd come from a bar, not from a blackout in the ether.

"Paul?" I asked, not sure which of us had said it.

He gave me a sideways grin. "Paul Lacuna," he said, casually. "That's what I went by in New York, anyway. Is it my real name?"

I blinked. "That's our name, yes."

"Well, that's something."

Before I could process that, before I could speak again, another ripple cut through the void.

A third figure emerged, slower this time. Sturdier. Neater. Wearing a fitted black tee, brown boots, olive jacket — more professional, a little older, but not wiser. His eyes narrowed when he saw the two of us already standing there.

"What the hell is this?" he asked, his voice lower, calmer.

"D.C.," the second me muttered. "Has to be."

"I'm Paul Lacuna," D.C. said.

"As are we," New York replied.

"There are two of you," said D.C. "Did I... Did *we*... get wiped again?"

"We must have," said New York. They both turned to me.

I didn't know how much to tell them. I hadn't expected this. I thought my memories would just return somehow.

"This is impossible," I muttered. "You can't be real. You're just... figments."

"If I'm right in thinking, we're more than that. We're echoes," D.C. said. "Fragments you split off when you wiped us."

The silence that followed was complete. The three of us stood there, face to face to face, a trinity fractured across time and trauma, each one holding a different chapter of the same story.

"I didn't wipe us. You did. Then the second time, they did it against our will."

New York and D.C. looked at each other, shared a look, but didn't speak. What now?" I asked quietly.

New York smiled. "You completed our Safe Word Sequence, right?"

I nodded.

"Then we finish what you started." D.C. extended his hand, slow and deliberate. "We merge."

Boston me — I — reached out.

New York joined us, his fingers slotting into mine.

The instant our hands touched, the black around us cracked. Light burst outward, not blinding but deep. Bright like memory. Heavy like truth.

And then — the world unspooled.

And I remembered.

It was spring in D.C., and the cherry blossoms had begun to bloom along the canal near Georgetown. Claire held her camera in both hands like it was an extension of her body, moving fluidly from angle to angle, crouching low, climbing a bench, biting her lip as she adjusted the focus. I stood back and watched, not quite sure if I was more mesmerised by the pink canopy over the water or by her.

She wore a threadbare Bowie T-shirt tucked into high-waisted jeans, hair tied up in a messy bun with strands falling into her eyes. A camera bag slapped gently against her hip with every step. I'd been on a couple of dates with her before this, each one better than the last, but this one... this was the first time I realised I wanted to see her every day.

“You’re staring,” she said without looking up.

“Yeah,” I admitted. “I do that.”

She glanced at me then, smiled behind the camera. “You’re lucky you’re cute.”

“I get that a lot.”

“You’re full of shit.”

I stepped closer, close enough to smell the faint scent of bergamot on her skin, like her perfume had faded through the day but still clung to her.

“What can I say? I like watching you work.”

She lowered the camera and gave me a long, appraising look. “You like watching me do anything, I’ve noticed.”

“Guilty as charged.”

Claire laughed and slipped the camera back into the bag. “Okay, voyeur. Let’s go eat.”

She laced her fingers with mine as we walked down the path, the breeze carrying petals past our feet. We didn’t say much at first — just listened to the city around us. She swung our hands between us like we were already five years into something that hadn’t even started properly yet.

Then, as we crossed a little arched footbridge, she stopped and looked at me seriously.

“I like this,” she said.

“Cherry blossoms?”

“This. You. Me. Us.”

I blinked, surprised by the sincerity in her voice. It was sudden, but not too soon. Not with her.

“Yeah,” I said softly. “Me too.”

We kissed right there, beneath the arch of the bridge, surrounded by blossoms and the smell of spring and sunshine. It wasn’t deep, or hungry, or rushed — it was the kind of kiss that made promises without needing words.

I didn’t know then how complicated things would get. How far we’d fall from that moment. But in that flash of memory, I felt it again, like it was new.

The beginning. The spark.

The reason I ever loved her at all.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 4%

It had rained that evening. One of those short, sudden summer storms that drenched everything, then disappeared like it had never happened. We'd run the last couple of hundred yards into her apartment, soaked through, laughing and breathless, her hair clinging to her cheeks, my shirt sticking to my back.

Claire stripped off her wet jacket the second the door closed. I enjoyed the way her T-shirt hugged her chest, damp and semi-transparent, the outline of her bra faint beneath it. She kicked off her boots, peeled the shirt over her head, and tossed it on the couch like it was nothing.

"Do you want a towel or just your dignity back?" she teased, eyes dancing.

I realised I was utterly drenched, probably looked like a drowned rat. "I'll take both, but I'm fine waiting on the dignity part."

She laughed and disappeared into the bathroom. I stood there dripping, half-hard already, adrenaline from the run building arousal, fast and warm.

When she came back, she was holding two towels and wearing nothing but a pair of cotton shorts and that bra — black, delicate, a little lacy. Her stomach was flat, a pale stretch of skin between the waistband and the underwire, and she looked... sexy. There was no other word to describe her.

I dried off in the kitchen while she poured us wine, and we sat on the couch together with the TV playing something neither of us watched. I don't remember what we talked about. I just remember how she leaned into me, legs crossed over mine, wineglass in one hand, fingers brushing the back of my neck with the other.

When I kissed her, she tasted like cabernet and rain. Her mouth moved slowly against mine at first, deliberate, exploratory. And then she set the glass aside and climbed into my lap, straddling me, her hands tangling in my hair as our mouths opened wider, deeper.

I slid my hands up her back, feeling her arch into me. Her bra unclasped easily. She shrugged it off without breaking the kiss, then pulled my damp

shirt over my head.

Everything after that felt inevitable.

She stood and took my hand, led me to the bedroom like it was hers — because it was — and tugged down her shorts before I even made it to the doorway. She stood there in nothing but black panties, backlit by the glow of a bedside lamp, and I stared at her body like I'd never seen a naked woman before. Her tits were full, perfectly shaped. Her nipples were pink, stiff from the cold. When she reached for me, I didn't hesitate.

We fell into bed, limbs entwined, mouths rediscovering each other with every shift and sigh. She guided my hand between her legs, moaned when my fingers slid beneath the silk and found her already wet. Her pussy was shaved, save for a thin landing strip of soft, fine hair. I kissed her chest, her collarbone, her tits, sucked a nipple gently, and then moved lower. Her breath caught when I kissed her inner thigh.

“Oh god,” she moaned. “That feels so fucking good.”

“Yeah?”

“Yes. Don't stop.”

I didn't.

After I'd made her cum with my tongue, I positioned myself over her, scarcely able to believe I was about to fuck this gorgeous woman. When I slid inside her, slow and careful, her dark eyes locked on mine. She didn't close them, didn't look away. Just stayed with me, every inch of the way.

It wasn't rushed. It wasn't rough. It was perfect.

After, we lay tangled in the sheets, her head on my chest, my arm around her waist, the storm long gone.

And I remember thinking — I could love this woman.

I think maybe I already did.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 9%

It started with a simple search.

Claire had gone to meet a friend for drinks, leaving me alone in the apartment with a half-finished bottle of red and an idle mind. I was looking

for a folder of edited shots she'd promised to share — she'd told me they were on her desktop, inside a drive labelled "Venice Shoot." I needed one of the photos for an invite design I was putting together for a work event. She'd given me permission, even told me her password weeks ago — "ZiggyDust7" — a Bowie reference, obviously.

I logged in, and at first, everything looked normal. Folders, data exports, camera backups. But as I scrolled, I noticed one folder tucked away, and for whatever reason, it caught my eye:

CHEAT CODES

Maybe that was it? It wasn't the folder she'd told me to look for, but something told me to look. And I did.

I shouldn't have. But a part of me did — the part that had started seeing little shifts in her expression when I asked about her nights out, about work, about other little things that I'd noticed, changes in her.

Inside were text files. Dozens of them. Each named as a journal entry with a date. I hovered over one, wondering what I was about to see. My heart was already pounding.

I clicked.

He smiled at me again today. Adam. There's something about him, something in the way he looks at me. Something I think I want to know more about.

My breath caught.

Paul loves me. I know he does. But I wonder what he'd do if he knew what I imagined last night. Adam, behind me. Paul in front of me. Them both inside me at the same time.

I clicked on another.

It's not that I want to be unfaithful. It's that I want Paul to watch me be unfaithful. With his permission. With his hunger in his eyes. God, I can see it so clearly. His hand in his lap, his cock hard, his eyes on mine while I take someone else inside me.

I felt sick. I felt like a voyeur. But I couldn't stop.

The next file was longer. More detailed.

Tonight, I touched myself while Paul was asleep next to me. I imagined him waking up and telling me to go on. That he wanted to see. That he'd invite someone else to help. I came thinking about it. Not about the other man. About Paul letting it happen.

It got worse. It wasn't just fantasies. The journal entries continued over time. She'd gone through with it, fucked him. And others. I read more and more entries, unable to stop.

My erection was hard and awkward in my pants, painful even, tangled in the guilt of what I was reading. This wasn't just a betrayal — it was all of her secrets. Her confessions. Her darkest, most erotic fantasies and how and when she'd fulfilled them. But she hadn't fulfilled them all yet. Some of them involved *me*. Me, her and someone else.

That night, I didn't sleep. I lay beside her, pretending to breathe evenly, trying to reconcile the ache in my groin with the confusion in my chest.

I didn't tell her. Not yet. Everything had changed. And it was never going back.

UPLOAD PACKET COMPLETE 12%

The hotel room was lit by the soft amber glow of a single lamp, positioned just right to paint Claire in gold. She stood at the foot of the bed in black lingerie — lace, sheer, it showed everything. She'd worn it with the camera in mind. My camera.

I remember how steady my hands were. How unreal it felt. The surreal calm that blanketed the room, even as my stomach twisted into knots I couldn't name. She turned toward the lens, eyes locked on it — on me.

"Hey, baby. Are you ready for this?"

"I think so," I replied, my heart thudding with excitement. "Are you sure about this, Claire?"

I recorded her as she spoke. "I'm sure. I want this. I want you to see this."

"I want you to remember this," she said, lips parted, voice low. "Not just what happens tonight. But why. I need you to remember that this was your idea."

Adam arrived at that moment. I watched them fuck. Recorded it all. Captured every detail as he took my wife right in front of me. Ever since I'd finally talked to her about her cheating. Confessed to her that it turned me on, that I wanted to fulfil her fantasies, I'd looked forward to this moment,

and it didn't disappoint. I'd never enjoyed anything more than watching my wife get fucked — properly fucked — by Adam and his big cock.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 18%

The elevator to Elysium HQ didn't have buttons. Just a biometric panel that scanned Harry's palm, then mine, before gliding silently upward. The walls were mirrored. We stood there in our best suits, reflections multiplied endlessly in every direction.

"I hate this Willy Wonka bullshit," Harry muttered under his breath.

I chuckled. "You love this shit. Secret labs, mystery projects, off-the-books funding. It's your wet dream."

"It was. Until we had to sign an NDA thicker than your mom's lasagna sauce just to get an interview."

The elevator dinged with a muted chime and opened into a glass corridor. Clean, cold lines. White floors, chrome accents. Elysium looked like the kind of place where nothing messy ever happened, where even the air felt manufactured and artificial.

A tall man in a slate-grey suit waited for us at the end of the corridor. He didn't smile. Just gestured for us to follow.

He led us into a boardroom that felt more like a museum exhibit — a polished real stone table, a single wall of dark glass that might've been a window or a screen. And waiting for us, two women.

One sat at the head of the table, legs crossed, hands folded, her stare sharp enough to draw blood. The CEO of Elysium. Middle-aged but still fuckable, if she wasn't so intimidating with her deep eyes and long stare. Eleanor Gass.

And the other was a bombshell of a redhead with long legs and full lips. I knew her now as Rachel. But I didn't know her then. Not yet.

She stood as we entered, tall and graceful. Fiery hair pulled into a sleek twist, fitted black dress hugging her curves like it had been engineered for it. She extended a hand first to me, then to Harry.

“Rachel Gass,” she said. “Chief Technical Officer. We’re excited to meet you. Your résumés were perfect. We’ve read a lot about you both.”

Her voice was smooth and professional, but her eyes lingered on me just a second too long. Harry clocked it instantly. He raised an eyebrow as we sat, invited to the table by the older woman waiting for us.

Eleanor wasted no time. “Your references are exemplary,” she said, her tone clipped, businesslike. “Nadia Kowalski herself recommended we hire you, before she... left the company. She wanted you on her team, but now you’ll be replacing her instead, the two of you.”

“I know some of her work,” Harry said. “I’ve studied her NeuralLink layering models. Some of it was... ambitious.”

“You’ll find,” Eleanor said, folding her hands tighter, “That ambition is welcome here. As long as it’s controlled.”

Rachel leaned forward, her gaze flicking between us. “You’ll be working on a classified project. Internally, we call it Clean Slate. It’s a neural reconditioning technology with the ability to wipe selective memory—trauma, toxic behaviours, phobias. And potentially... other things.”

Harry sat up straighter. “You’re serious? Kowalski developed the chip she mentioned in her blogs?”

“We’re always serious,” Eleanor said coolly. “Yes. Hard Core is real. It just needs someone to continue working on it, to develop the software to maximise the potential of the hardware.”

Rachel smiled again — this time directly at me. “You’ll be helping us finish what Nadia started. You’ll have full access to her research.”

That smile lingered. Her lip curled ever so slightly. I felt a sudden, inexplicable warmth in my chest. I loved her. Not then. But now, somehow. I didn’t understand it, but there it was.

When the meeting ended, with Harry and me both now employees of Elysium, she walked us to the elevator. Her hand brushed mine as she passed me a slim access card.

“I look forward to us working closely together,” she said.

Harry snickered softly, but I ignored him. “Me too,” I replied.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 24%

The sheets were tangled, damp with sweat. The bedroom glowed in the light from the street outside, the only sound the quiet hiss of the city beyond the cracked-open window. Claire lay sprawled across the bed between us, one leg hooked over mine, her arm slung lazily across Harry's chest. Her long, dark hair was wild, stuck to her forehead in curls. Her naked breasts rose and fell in a lazy rhythm, still catching her breath.

I turned my head and met Harry's eyes across the pillow. He looked calm. A little smug. Beads of sweat dripped down his forehead.

"Well, that was unexpected," he muttered, his voice low and gravel-edged.

Claire giggled and rolled onto her back. "Speak for yourself. I've been thinking about that for weeks."

I grinned, brushing her hair back from her face. "So this wasn't just a spur-of-the-moment thing?"

Claire gave me a look. "Paul. I knew from the exact moment I met the pair of you that I wanted to fuck both of you."

Harry laughed. "So it wasn't that time I beat you at Mario Kart? Because I know that impressed you."

She raised her eyebrows. "You were the first to beat me, but the fact you played as Princess Peach was a bit of a turn-off, actually."

We all laughed, the kind of laugh that comes only after something risky turns out right. But underneath it, there was something else too — an energy, a crackle. This was new territory, and we were still finding our way.

Claire shifted to sit up, the sheets falling to her waist. I saw Harry's eyes drift to her breasts. He'd had his cock between them half an hour before, fucking them while she pushed them together for him. She glanced at us both with a kind of lazy fondness. "So... tell me again what this new project is. The reason you're both so excited to be working at Elysium."

Harry sighed and sat up against the headboard. "We're still under NDA."

Claire reached for the wine glass on the nightstand, took a sip, then gave him a flat look. "You literally just came in my mouth. I think we're past NDAs."

I laughed again, shaking my head. Harry groaned, rubbing his face.

“All right,” I said. “Top line? It’s called Clean Slate. Neural manipulation. The ability to selectively erase or modify memories.”

Claire blinked, glass halfway to her lips.

“You’re joking. That sounds... dangerous.”

Harry’s grin faded. “Not joking. Not even close. It’s already been tested in rodents. Basic phobia erasure. And now human adaptation is being phased in. That’s our project.”

Claire looked between us. “Jesus. That’s...”

“Amazing,” I said.

“Terrifying,” she said.

“Both,” Harry added.

Claire set her glass down. “And you two think this is a good idea?”

I shrugged. “Totally. The original designer created it for trauma. PTSD. Breaking destructive patterns, but the potential is there for so much more.”

She tilted her head. “And what about abuse? What about corporations, if they get their hands on this tech? Governments? What about erasing something just because it’s inconvenient?”

Harry didn’t say anything. I looked at him. “You’re thinking it too, aren’t you?”

He nodded slowly. “Of course I am. That’s why we need to be the ones building it. Not someone else. Who would you trust more than us to develop this?”

Claire leaned back, chewing her lip, deep in thought. “Well,” she said finally, reaching for both of us again. “Just don’t erase this memory.”

Her hands slipped under the sheet, one of them finding my cock and stroking it slowly. The way Harry grinned told me her other hand was doing the same to him, and then the conversation quickly gave way to something else entirely.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 27%

The lab was cold, even by Elysium’s standards. So cold that the laser-cleaned white surfaces felt like ice to the touch. There was a reason. The

cold made the processors work more efficiently, but it felt like being inside a glacier designed by an architect with no love for people.

Harry was bent over a tablet, muttering to himself, fingers flicking through layers of neural code. I stood at the console opposite, rerouting the memory wipe simulator through a mock-up NeuroLink Crown interface. We were simulating short-term extraction at first — ten minutes of recall, stripped and fragmented.

“This bit here,” I said, pointing at a cascading line of synaptic pulse data. “It’s too volatile. That’s where the interference spikes. The chip’s responding faster than the regulator.”

Harry frowned. “We lower the regulator, it loses fidelity.”

“We keep it this fast, it burns the brain.”

He exhaled through his nose. “We’ll find a way.”

The door opened behind us and Eleanor Gass entered, all dark clothing, hard eyes and tight lips. Rachel followed a step behind, dressed more casually than usual — her hair loose, a sweater instead of one of her power-dresses. She gave me a small smile. I didn’t return it.

Eleanor crossed the lab without a word and studied the data streams over my shoulder. “Still unstable?” she said finally.

“We’re close,” I answered. “The interface works. Memory modulation and overwrite is possible, but only in controlled bursts. Longer durations, more permanent restructuring — that’s the next phase.”

Eleanor didn’t nod. She never nodded. She absorbed.

Harry straightened. “This would be easier if we knew the use-case model. Right now, we’re engineering a scalpel for surgery, and you won’t tell us what you want to cut.”

Rachel spoke this time. “What if we wanted to cut fear?”

Harry raised an eyebrow. “Fear’s good. Keeps people alive.”

Eleanor turned, pinning him with that gaze that could freeze lava.

“Fear is messy. We want perfection.”

“And if we want compliance,” Rachel added softly, “We need to eliminate resistance. That starts in the mind. It starts with fear.”

I felt a subtle chill and not from the cold room. “You want to use this for reconditioning, not for compliance.”

Rachel tilted her head. “People have to comply if they want therapy and rehabilitation.”

“We need to be able to influence their emotions,” Eleanor added.

Harry scoffed. “There’s a difference between compliance and influence and what you’re talking about. I read your notes and comments on the project mission. It sounds more like control to me.”

Eleanor moved to the wall screen and tapped it. It bloomed to life with a video — an Elysium presentation. Pie charts. Projections. Neural heat maps. “What we’re building,” she said, “is freedom. Freedom from trauma. From toxicity. From the limitations of choice when choice leads to chaos. Clean Slate is about giving people their lives back. Better ones.”

“Or giving them the lives *you* want them to have,” Harry muttered.

Rachel walked closer to me, her voice low. “You’re the one who said the real money’s in bad decisions, Paul. You were right. Everyone wants a reset.”

I didn’t answer. I watched the screen — flashes of brains lighting up under stimulation, before and after clips of personalities subtly altered. And beneath it all, I felt it. Clean Slate wasn’t just science anymore. It was strategy. It was power.

And I was helping build it.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 35%

We were at The Wren again, our usual Friday post-lab watering hole. It was dark, too hip for me and overpriced. But they made a decent Old Fashioned, and the booth in the back let us talk in relative peace. Harry had already knocked back half of his, ice clinking in the glass as he tilted it lazily.

I sipped mine more slowly. I was still thinking about the night before. Claire had been different. Something was off, and I didn’t know what it was. Since we’d opened up our relationship, she told me everything. So for her to be acting weirdly without an explanation put me on edge.

Harry tapped the table with two fingers. “So, I told Annmarie.”

My brain took a second to catch up. “Told her what?”

He raised a brow. “About Claire.”

I blinked. “You did *what*?”

He laughed, the sound more tense than amused. “Relax. Not everything. Not the whole Elysium mess. Just... us. You. Her. The thing.”

“The thing,” I echoed flatly. “You told your wife that my wife fucks other men while I watch or join in?”

Harry leaned in, grinning. “No. Yes. More than that. I told her that *you and I* were exploring something different. That I’d slept with Claire. And that it was consensual with you. That we’d shared her. That we were... testing boundaries between us.”

I stared at him. “I know we’ve been wondering what to do about Annmarie, but... You told her?”

He shrugged. “I expected a slap. Tears. Maybe a divorce.”

“And?”

“She went quiet. Asked questions. Then she said she was curious.”

My jaw tightened. “Curious? She didn’t go mad?”

He leaned back in the booth, arms stretched over the leather. “She asked if I wanted to fuck Claire again. I said yes. Then she asked if you’d want to fuck *her*.”

The table between us suddenly felt very small.

“And you said...?”

“I said I didn’t know.” Harry’s grin faded, just a little. “But you always liked her. Even before Claire. I remember you telling me how cute you thought she was. Before I asked her out.”

I ran a hand through my hair, trying to untangle the feelings that sentence stirred. He wasn’t wrong. I liked Annmarie. A lot. She was funny, sharp, grounded in a way Claire wasn’t. She saw through Harry’s bullshit better than anyone. But this?

“This is serious,” I said, after a long moment. “Claire and I are into this. We’re built for it. Not all marriages are. It’s not a game.”

“No,” Harry agreed. “It’s an escape.”

I looked at him.

“From guilt. From secrets. Claire’s already tiring of it just being you and me. You know it. She’s itching to move on to the next guy. But if Annmarie comes into it — ”

“I don’t know if she’ll be into it,” I said quietly. “I’ll talk to her, but don’t get your hopes up.”

“Three’s a triangle,” Harry said, finishing his drink. “There’s always one on the periphery. But four? That’s a square. Closed. Safe. No one left out.”

I laughed despite myself. “You’re so full of shit.”

“Maybe.” He slid the empty glass to the edge of the table. “But I think you are, too. If you’re saying you don’t want to fuck Annmarie.”

I didn’t answer. But my silence wasn’t denial. And we both knew it.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 42%

The conference room had never been this full, or this quiet.

Harry and I had barely set down our tablets before Eleanor swept in, her coat still half draped over one shoulder. Rachel followed, more composed, but there was a charged edge to her movements I hadn’t seen before. Jean-Marc, the lover of Claire’s, who I’d thought was a friend, but turned out to be nothing more than a social climber, was already at the far end of the table, phone in hand, thumb flicking across the screen like he was waiting for a war to start.

When Eleanor spoke, it wasn’t loud — but it cut through the room like a knife.

“We have a major problem.”

Rachel set a tablet down on the table, the screen facing Harry and me. A grainy transcript sat open, scrolling lines of captured audio. The header read: “N. KOWALSKI — Unauthorised Access.”

Harry leaned in. “Nadia?”

Rachel nodded. “Your predecessor.”

I frowned. “I thought she quit.”

“She did,” Eleanor said flatly. “She developed concerns about the ethical boundaries of Clean Slate. Concerns that became... disruptive.”

“Unmanageable,” Rachel added.

My chest tightened. I had a bad feeling about this. “So what’s the problem?”

“She was reset,” Eleanor said, like it was a standard HR policy. “We had to protect the project. The terms of her development of this project using Elysium funding included a reset if she ever left the project.”

“A memory wipe?” Harry asked. “Without proper human testing?”

There was a silence. Rachel broke it.

“She knew the terms and agreed to them.”

I found that hard to believe. I looked at everyone in the room, trying to process what I’d heard. “You wiped your lead engineer to protect Clean Slate. Why?”

“She was compensated,” Jean-Marc said without looking up.

“She was a liability,” Eleanor added, flashing a look at Jean-Marc that instantly silenced him. “And the problem is that somehow, she’s regained her memories. She accessed the Elysium servers unauthorised. Gained access to your source files. Code notes. She’s hacked us.”

“And she’s talking to someone,” Rachel added, gesturing to the transcript. “An investigative journalist. She’s not using her name, yet. But from our server logs, we know it’s her.”

Harry sat back, eyes narrowed. “But you’ve managed to secure the firewall now?”

Eleanor gave him a cool look, then nodded.

“We should change the name to protect the project,” I said, thinking aloud. “I’ve always thought that Fresh Start is a more apt title for it.”

“Whatever.” Rachel leaned forward. “We can do that, but we need to know that you can be trusted. If this woman reaches out to you, we need to be informed.”

“Why is she doing this?” Harry asked Eleanor, not acknowledging Rachel’s request. “Is it because of your intentions for its implementation?”

Eleanor stood, gathering her coat with a flick. “You’re not here to question the ethics. You’re here to complete the work.”

She paused at the door. “If what she is saying gets out, she could expose the whole operation. And you’ll both be out of a job. Or worse.” Then she left, Rachel giving us both one last look — unreadable — before following her out.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 49%

I was in a dim room, lit only by the warm spill of a lamp on the dresser and the slow-moving headlights on the road beyond the hotel window. The sheets were already half off the bed, twisted at the foot, strewn with discarded clothing — Claire's bra, Harry's shorts, Annmarie's panties.

I was on my back, soaked in sweat, breath still catching as Claire curled against my side. Her lips grazed my collarbone, lazy now, a far cry from the desperate heat of a few minutes earlier. Beside us, Harry lay with his arm thrown behind his head, staring at the ceiling like it had just told him something he didn't want to believe. Annmarie was between me and Harry, her hair a mess of cum-soaked blonde waves spilling across my chest, her leg still hooked over mine, her feet touching Claire's.

None of us spoke for a while.

Eventually, Claire murmured, "That was fucking awesome."

Harry laughed softly, though it sounded more like disbelief than amusement. "You think?"

Annmarie stirred but didn't lift her head. "My face is covered in cum. Can someone get a towel? Oh, and I can't feel my thighs."

"You didn't seem to have a problem using them while you were riding my husband's cock," Claire said, grinning.

"I'm not complaining," Annmarie mumbled. "Just letting you know if you expect me to walk to the bathroom to get my own towel, someone's carrying me."

Harry laughed, then got up, heading to the bathroom before returning with a towel. As he passed it to her, he turned his head, looking at me over Annmarie as she sat up to clean the cum from her face. "You okay?"

I nodded. "Yeah. That was mind-blowing. I'm just... trying to file this away in the right mental folder."

Claire's hand slipped down my stomach, fingers trailing, teasing, finding my cock and stroking it softly. "You mean the one labelled *What the fuck did we just do?*"

That got a laugh from all of us, but underneath the humour, something deeper simmered. This hadn't been planned. Not really. We'd discussed it, but none of us expected it to happen right away. It had started with a look between Claire and Annmarie the night before. Then a drunken dare. Harry suggested the two girls get in on while we watched. Which they had done. Before we joined them. Then we'd spent all the next day fucking.

Annmarie finally pushed herself up, brushing hair from her face, her expression less playful now. “So, is this... a thing?” she asked. “Or was this just a one-time experiment?”

No one answered immediately. After a moment, Claire sat up next to her, touching her arm. The sight of my wife naked, next to Annmarie, with her similarly-sized breasts and equally perfect body exposed next to her, sent a thrill through me. “Do you want it to be a thing?”

Annmarie hesitated, then looked at me. “Fuck, yes.”

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 55%

The basement lab didn’t usually hold meetings like this. It wasn’t a conference space, not officially — it was for diagnostics, hardware testing, NeuroLink Crown tuning. But tonight, the air was thick with something more than the usual ozone scent of newly printed circuitry.

Rachel stood at the far wall, arms folded, fingers tapping a steady rhythm on her sleeve. Eleanor sat in one of the high-backed swivel chairs, spine straight, expression unreadable. Harry paced near the neural monitor, eyes narrowed in thought. I was at the command terminal, the interface lit with the biometric trace of someone we were tracking.

Nadia Kowalski

And then Marcus walked in.

His hair was a mess, his glasses smudged, his coat thrown on like he hadn’t decided whether to stay or leave. He stopped just inside the threshold, eyes flicking to the screen, then to each of us in turn.

“You’re doing it,” he said, voice low. “You’re bringing her in.”

Eleanor didn’t move. “The decision was made. Our agents have her.”

Marcus stepped further in. “You’re going to reset her again. Aren’t you?”

“She’s a threat to operational security,” Rachel said simply.

“Because you wiped her in the first place!”

“She’s broken her NDA, Marcus,” I said, though even to my own ears, it sounded thin. “She knows what she’s doing. We had no option.”

“Kidnapping. Memory wiping without consent. That’s not in the NDA.” His hand gestured to the terminal, where the neural schematic of Nadia’s brain pulsed faintly. “You’ve gone beyond ethics. Beyond reasonable. This is illegal.”

“She’s the one being unreasonable,” Harry muttered, still pacing. “She’s been offered a fortune to sign a new NDA — ”

“She designed Hard Core. If she now wants to stop us, what we’re doing, maybe there’s a valid reason. Maybe we should listen to her,” he snapped.

Eleanor finally stood. “Enough.”

Her heels echoed across the floor as she approached Marcus. She was taller than him, just slightly, but in that moment she seemed to tower.

“You’re here to engineer, not moralise,” she said. “We gave you that lab, that title, that stock package. Don’t pretend you didn’t know what we were building.”

Marcus clenched his jaw. “I knew. I just didn’t think we’d become the villains of our own story.”

Rachel stepped forward. “You don’t have to be part of it. Walk away.”

His laugh was hollow. “You mean until I remember something inconvenient, and you come for me too?”

No one spoke. He stared at us a moment longer, then turned and walked out, slamming the door behind him.

Eleanor looked at me. “Prepare the Crown. Our agents have her. She’ll be here tomorrow.”

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 57%

The hotel suite was the best I’d ever stayed in. The king-sized bed was the biggest I’d slept in. Not that I’d spent much time sleeping. Rachel was curled against me, her naked skin warm against mine, her hair fanned across the pillow like dark copper silk.

She didn’t speak for a while, just breathed, the calm kind that only came after a long, slow fuck. She was different after sex. Softer. But not

vulnerable — never that. If anything, she was more dangerous like this. Disarmed, and disarming.

“You’re quiet,” she murmured eventually.

“Just thinking.”

She looked up, propping herself on one elbow. “About her?”

I hesitated. The question didn’t surprise me. The edge in her voice did.

“I wasn’t,” I said. “But now...”

Rachel smiled faintly. “You shouldn’t feel guilty. She’s fucking around too. Everyone knows.”

That landed like a slap. “Claire and I — ”

“Are lying to yourselves,” Rachel interrupted gently. “Jean-Marc and Harry have both fucked her, and God knows who else. Probably Marcus. You think people don’t talk?”

I shifted beneath her. “It’s complicated.”

Rachel laughed under her breath, then leaned in, kissed me — slow and wet, her hand sliding down beneath the sheets again. “No, Paul. It’s simple. You deserve better. You want better. That’s why you’re in this bed tonight with me, and not with her.”

Her grip tightened around my cock, slow strokes reigniting the heat we’d just exhausted.\

“I’m here because you wanted this in exchange for keeping quiet about me using the code console out of hours.”

“But you’re here,” she said, kissing my neck now. My hips were moving in time with her hand. She knew how to turn me on. “And you’ve not made any move to go home.”

I hadn’t. And I hated that I hadn’t.

When she finally climbed on top of me again, guiding me inside her pussy, fuzzy with her fine red hair, and did a slow roll of her hips, her eyes never leaving mine. There was something in them I couldn’t quite read — hunger, yes. But something else too. Possession.

She rode me slowly, deliberately, the tempo torturously sensual, whispering into my ear between soft moans. Her tits were small, perfect. I craned my neck to take them into my mouth.

“She’s not yours anymore,” she moaned as I clamped my lips around her nipple. “She lets Jean-Marc fuck her whenever he wants. You don’t owe her any loyalty. You owe it to me.”

I was going to question that but then she leaned back, riding my cock with such ferocity that she swept any words I was going to say clean out of my mind.

The worst thing was, I wasn't even thinking of Claire to start off with. I was thinking of Annmarie.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 62%

The room looked more like a spa than a surgical suite.

Soft light panels glowed through frosted glass, punctuating walls of white glossy plastic. A faint, artificial scent of lavender piped through unseen vents. Elysium's way of making violation feel like care. Like comfort.

Nadia lay motionless in the chair, her eyes closed, the NeuroLink Crown fitted snug over her skull. Her blue hair fanned out beneath the padded headrest, her features serene in the kind of way only sedation could produce. Even unconscious, she radiated intelligence. Defiance.

I adjusted the parameters on the console beside her. My fingers didn't shake. I told myself that meant I was ready. Harry stood behind me, arms folded, watching the monitor that tracked synaptic activity in real time. We weren't talking much, Harry and I. Not anymore.

The silence was broken when the door burst open.

Marcus strode in, his coat flaring behind him as he strode in, his voice already raised. "What the fuck are you doing?"

Harry turned, his body instinctively blocking Marcus's view of the screen. "You need to leave."

"She's not a machine," Marcus snapped. "She's a person."

I kept working, balancing the nodes. If I looked at him, I might stop. I couldn't stop.

"This is a soft reset," I said. "It's just suppressing —"

"Just?" Marcus stepped around Harry. "You're lobotomising her! Again! After she already clawed her way back to herself once?"

"She's unstable," Harry said. "A threat to everything the three of us have worked on. She's already contacted a journalist."

“Then let her talk!” Marcus was shaking now. “Let the world hear what we’re building down here before it’s too late.”

Rachel appeared in the doorway, arms crossed. “It’s already too late for that.”

Marcus turned to her, stunned. “You’re sanctioning this?”

“I’m *ordering* it,” she said calmly. “Step outside. Now.”

“No,” he said. “I won’t let you do this.”

Rachel didn’t flinch. “You already did. The minute you accepted your bonus. The minute you didn’t walk out last month.”

He looked at me then. Not Rachel. Not Harry. Me.

“Paul,” he said, quieter now. “You’re better than this. I know you. You *care* about what you build. Don’t let them use you like this.”

I looked at Nadia’s face. At the pulsing waveforms on the screen. At the line of code I was about to inject that would lock down everything she’d spent months trying to reclaim.

“I’m sorry,” I whispered, then pressed the key.

Marcus made a sound — half disbelief, half grief.

The monitor beeped. Her brainwaves dipped.

Harry’s eyes flicked to me. “It’s done.”

Rachel nodded. “Good.”

Marcus turned and left without another word.

I stared at the screen for a long time after he was gone, watching the green lines settle into a placid rhythm. Predictable. Controlled.

“We’re going to have to do something about him,” Rachel said, staring after Marcus once he’d left.

And for the first time since joining Elysium, I wasn’t sure if we were still the good guys.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 69%

We were on the couch in her apartment, half-dressed, the remnants of a shared bottle of wine between us. Annmarie sat cross-legged beside me, a blanket wrapped around her waist, her bare shoulders kissed gold by the

glow of the single floor lamp. Her hair was a little longer then. Darker. Tucked behind her ears, the way she always did when she was trying not to cry.

“You shouldn’t have done it,” she said softly.

I didn’t answer.

“I know she was a threat,” she added, not looking at me. “But no one deserves that. No one should have their memories ripped from them. Memories... they’re our most precious gift.”

“Rachel ordered it,” I said, voice flat. “She was going to expose us.”

The silence between us stretched until she finally turned to face me. “Paul... I’m scared.”

I blinked. “Of what?”

“Of what you’re becoming.”

That landed like a gut punch. I wanted to argue, to defend myself, but I couldn’t find the words. Because a part of me — the part that hadn’t been touched by Rachel’s hands or Eleanor’s promises — agreed with her.

Annmarie reached for my hand, her fingers warm and firm. “You don’t have to stay in this. You can leave. With me.”

I looked at her, at the earnest desperation in her eyes. At the hope she still held on to. “You want to run away?”

“I’m scared,” she said. “If this is how they treat people, what’s stopping them from doing it to you?”

“I can’t just leave.” I swallowed hard. “It’s not that simple.”

“It is,” she said. “They’ll keep using you until there’s nothing left. And when you finally realise it, you’ll be alone. Like Nadia was. Like Marcus is now.” She leaned in, kissed my knuckles. “We can start over. We can disappear. Move to a new city, just you and me.”

I stared at the floor. My mind was a hurricane of conflicting thoughts — loyalty, guilt, fear, desire.

“Annmarie,” I said quietly, “I love you.”

She looked up at me, surprised. “Then leave with me.”

And God, I wanted to. I wanted to throw my badge and access card into the trash, walk out into the city with her hand in mine and never look back.

But there was Claire. And Harry. And a thousand other threads I didn’t know how to untangle.

“I need time,” I said. “To think.”

She didn't say anything else. Just leaned against me, her head on my shoulder, as we listened to the city keep moving around us.

And I stayed there, caught between the woman I could be free with, the woman I was married to, the woman I was trapped working for, and the future I didn't know how to escape.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 71%

The Elysium conference room smelled like coffee that had gone cold hours ago and something sharper — disinfectant, maybe, or the metallic tang of a hard truth about to be spoken. Eleanor was already seated at the head of the table when I arrived, her expression composed but unreadable. Rachel stood with one hand on the back of her chair, fingers tapping absently against the leather, her other hand tucked into the pocket of her cream blazer. Jean-Marc was near the far wall, arms crossed, jaw tight. His presence wasn't typical for internal debriefs, which set me on edge right away. At some point, he'd become Rachel's enforcer. Elysium's security-in-chief, if unofficially.

Harry sat across from me, silent, alert, unusually still. Like he already knew what was coming. But I didn't, and I was nervous.

Eleanor's tone was clinical when she spoke. "Nadia Kowalski passed away this morning."

For a beat, the words didn't compute. Then they dropped like a stone into my chest.

I blinked at her. "What?"

"She was found at her apartment," Rachel added, her voice lower but not softer. "Unresponsive. Paramedics couldn't revive her. The cause of death appears to be a seizure — that's what is going in the coroner's report. But we believe it to be from delayed neural shock, most likely related to the wipe procedure."

"But she was fine," I said. "She was fine when we discharged her. I checked her vitals. Her synaptic numbers were perfect. You saw them, Harry."

He nodded slowly, face unreadable. “Her stats were within tolerance. Her system looked stable.”

“It wasn’t the procedure,” Eleanor said. “It was the aftermath. A delayed cascade effect. Subcortical systems shutting down over time. She would have felt... off. Dizzy. Then her heart just stopped. She won’t have suffered any pain, if that makes you feel better.”

I felt my breath catch. Nadia had walked out of the recovery suite. She’d smiled — tired, sure, but lucid. Present. We thought we’d done it cleanly. No signs of damage. No errors in the code.

And now she was gone.

“No. I don’t fucking feel better. She died *alone*,” I said, more to myself than anyone else. “At home. After we told her she was okay.”

Jean-Marc gave a small, dispassionate shrug. “She was clearly unstable before the reset. Could’ve triggered something latent.”

My hands clenched under the table. “We told her it worked. We told her she was *safe*.”

“No,” Rachel corrected, cool as glass. “You told her she was safe. I advised against releasing her so early.”

“What?” I snapped. “You were the one that ordered the fucking reset.”

“I had to. Before Marcus fucked it up.”

Harry finally looked at me. His gaze wasn’t cold — but it wasn’t comforting either. “Maybe Marcus distracted us. Maybe we got something wrong.”

A silence fell over the room like a shroud. One that no one wanted to lift.

Eleanor exhaled slowly. “It doesn’t matter now. We’ll arrange for her belongings to be handled quietly. Her family won’t be involved — they signed full institutional custody when she joined. Legally, we are next of kin.”

It hit me like a slap. “You’re erasing her.”

“She erased herself when she went to the press,” Rachel said. “We’re just finishing the job.”

I stood abruptly, the chair scraping behind me. “I need to leave.”

“You’ll want to be back by two,” Eleanor said without looking up. “We have a board call.”

I walked out without answering, heart hammering, nausea curling in my gut. As I stepped into the hallway, the glass behind me reflected four distorted figures around a table.

But all I could see was Nadia's face.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 78%

The coastline looked like something out of a dream — muted, faded, washed in greys and blues. Rockport in the off-season was quiet enough to feel almost post-apocalyptic, the kind of silence that wrapped around you and made it impossible to ignore your thoughts. We'd rented a weathered little place up the hill from the harbour, its shingled roof warped with time, fireplace blackened with soot. The kind of house that didn't have Wi-Fi, or heating that worked reliably, or any sense of time. And that was the point. We weren't here to enjoy luxury and be high-profile vacationers. We were here to escape, to hide for a while.

Annmarie stood near the edge of the cliff path, the wind tangling her honey-blonde hair as she hugged her coat tighter around her. The sea stretched out endlessly behind her, the lighthouse to our left blinking lazily against the grey. She didn't say anything for a long time. Neither did I. There was too much to say and none of it was useful.

"I can't stop seeing her face," I said eventually, voice barely audible over the wind.

Annmarie didn't turn. Just nodded slowly, like she'd been expecting this to surface.

"She was supposed to be okay," I went on. "We checked her vitals, her EEG. Everything came back clean."

Annmarie turned then, eyes glassy. "I'm so sorry."

"I killed her," I said, and this time I felt it — sharp and jagged, slicing through my ribs from the inside. "I pushed the code. I pressed the button. I *watched* her walk out, thinking we'd gotten away with it. And then —"

"You didn't kill her," she said, stepping closer. "You didn't make the decision alone."

"No," I said. "But I *executed* it. I executed her."

She reached out, took my hand, her fingers trembling. "No. You need to stop thinking like this, Paul."

I shook my head, vision blurring. “She’s dead because of me.”

“Not because of you,” she insisted gently.

“And now they’ve silenced Marcus too.” The last good man left in that place. Wiped. Like it meant nothing. Like *hemeant* nothing. “They took him too.”

The wind cut through the space between us again. She stepped closer, both hands holding mine now. “Paul, you can’t go back there.”

I blinked. “What do you mean?”

“I mean it’s time. You have to walk away. Run away with me. Like we keep talking about.”

I looked at her then — really looked. Her eyes were tired, but clear. Her cheeks flushed from the cold, hair wild around her face. She looked more beautiful than ever. Not in that glamorous, curated way Claire always had — but in her own way. A real way.

“I’m not Claire,” she said softly, like she could read my mind. “And I know you loved her. Maybe a part of you still does. I’m not asking you to pretend she never mattered. But you and her... It’s too far gone. I love you, Paul. I’d do anything... *anything*... for you.”

I felt my breath catch. “I love you too.”

“Then come with me,” she said. “Before it’s too late.”

I stared at the sea behind her. At the lighthouse, blinking like some kind of failing heartbeat in the distance. I thought of Claire. Of Harry. Of Rachel. Of the growing cancer that Elysium had become.

And I almost said yes.

Almost.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 85%

Claire’s apartment was brightly lit. Too bright. Every light in the place was on, casting long shadows from the half-packed boxes lining the hallway. I stood in the doorway for a moment, watching her move around the living room like she was trying to clean away ghosts, tossing papers into folders,

wrapping glassware too fast, like if she moved fast enough, she wouldn't cry.

She looked up when she noticed me, brushing a stray lock of hair from her face. "Hey," she said, too casually. "You came."

I stepped inside, letting the door click shut behind me. "You texted."

Claire laughed softly, bitter and a little tired. "Yeah. I guess I did."

There was a silence. One of those heavy, humid ones that press down on your ribs.

"I'm leaving," she said eventually, setting down the glass she was packing and folding her arms. "I don't know where I'm going, but I'm leaving. I'm sorry. I can't do it anymore."

"You're not the only one," I said. "I already told Eleanor I'm out."

That made her look up, startled. "You did?"

"Last night."

"And?"

"She didn't argue. We made a deal."

Claire gave a soft snort. "Of course she did. She's already got Harry so far in her pocket, she doesn't need you anymore."

I hesitated. "Harry's leaving too."

That made her go still. "You're kidding."

"He says he's done. He can't handle what we did to Nadia. What Fresh Start is becoming. Where Eleanor wants us to go with the project. He knows he's lost Annmarie. He's lost you. He says he doesn't want to lose me too. If we're going to leave, we're leaving together."

Claire looked away then, out the window. "Jesus. We're all running, huh?"

Another silence stretched between us. She turned back slowly, her arms folded tightly now, protective.

"I know about you and Rachel," she said quietly.

I didn't deny it. "How?"

"Jean-Marc," she said, and I could see the sharpness flare in her eyes. "Apparently, she doesn't shut up about her trophies."

"It didn't mean anything," I said, too fast.

Claire tilted her head. "You're sure about that?"

"I was falling apart," I said. "She took advantage of me, plus she demanded it. In return for staying quiet about the secret project I've been working on."

“Secret project, huh?” Claire scoffed dismissively. “Whatever, Paul.”

“Wait,” I objected, irritated by her hypocrisy. “You were sleeping with Harry. With Jean-Marc. I don’t know who else. Why would you even care? We’ve become distant. I’ve been spending more time with Annmarie than my own wife. She’s a better friend than any of you.”

“Don’t you dare say I didn’t care,” she said, her voice suddenly raw. “You think I wanted this to go the way it did?”

“You made me a joke,” I said, louder now. “The entire office knew. Jean-Marc’s been bragging about fucking you to anyone that’ll listen.”

“I was *hurting*, Paul. I didn’t know how to handle what we’d become. What I’d become. And yeah, I screwed up. But so did you.”

We stared at each other across the space between us, the air thick with everything we hadn’t said for months.

“I’m leaving with Annmarie,” I said finally. “We’re getting out.”

Her eyes narrowed. “She’ll find out, you know.”

I didn’t answer.

“That you fucked Rachel. That you’re just as much a liar as the rest of us.”

“She deserves better,” I said. “I know that. But she’s the only chance of happiness that I’ve got left.”

Claire’s voice cracked. “I was your chance at happiness once.”

I felt the guilt like a punch to the chest. “I loved you.”

She nodded once, and for the first time in a long time, her eyes filled with tears. “And I loved you. But we poisoned it. All of us.”

Neither of us moved.

Then she turned, picked up a box, and walked into the bedroom, trying to leave the conversation behind, but I couldn’t leave it here. She needed to know the plan.

“Claire, the deal I made with Eleanor. You can get in too. I’ll pay for it.”

I followed her into the bedroom. She’d put the box on the bed and turned to face me, pushing a stray lock of dark hair out of her eyes. “What plan?”

“A way of getting out. Permanently. And getting rid of the pain.”

“Fresh Start?” she whispered, her dark eyes full of doubt.

I nodded. “It’s ready.”

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 90%

The holding room outside the surgical suite was too white. Not sterile, exactly, but blank in that way modern medical spaces are — faux-comfort, generic art on the walls, calming neutral tones that couldn't disguise the fact that this was where things ended.

I sat in one of the low chairs, elbows on knees, hands laced. Across from me, Claire perched on the edge of her seat, twisting her wedding ring over and over again on her finger. Harry stood by the window, his silhouette sharp against the backlit glass, arms folded, jaw clenched.

None of us spoke for a long time.

We'd already had the meeting with Eleanor. We'd signed the final documents, watched her slide the papers back into her folio like it was just another routine hire, another transaction. She'd promised everything would be clean. I'd be moved to New York, allowed to take the side-project that I'd been working on with me to develop further. Harry would be reassigned to a new office in Boston. At her own request, Claire would be given a new identity, a quiet reset here in D.C. Rachel would manage the transitions. Eleanor had said it like she was describing a real estate deal. Clean. Efficient. Final.

"I can't believe we're really doing this," Claire said at last, voice so soft I almost didn't catch it.

I looked up. "Can you think of another way?"

She didn't answer.

Harry turned from the window. "It's better this way. We fucked it all up. Wiping it clean is mercy."

"Mercy," Claire echoed. "That's one word for it."

I looked at Harry. "Do you ever wonder if we deserve the pain? Are we being cowards, taking this way out?"

He didn't flinch. "Every day, we deserve it, yes. But pain's not the same thing as redemption. This isn't us giving up. This is us choosing to live."

I wanted to believe that.

Claire glanced at me. "You spoke to Annmarie?"

I nodded, heart tight. "Yes."

“And she’s going with you to New York?” Claire already knew the answer.

“She said no.”

Of course she had. She said she couldn’t be part of something so hollow. That even if it broke her, she wanted me to *remember*. That love and pain weren’t real if it didn’t survive memory. That I was running away, but not in the way she wanted.

“She cried when I told her. Said I was a coward. Said she’d find me, someday, and bring me back. I told her not to. That it’d be better if she forgot me too.”

She said she wouldn’t. Not ever.

Footsteps echoed down the hall. Rachel appeared in the doorway, clipboard in hand, dressed in a lab coat this time. She looked... different. Cold. Detached.

“It’s time,” she said.

We stood, one by one. Claire took a long breath, slipped her ring off and left it on the armrest. Elysium had sorted the divorces for us. When we said this was a Fresh Start, we meant it.

Harry didn’t say a word. Just walked toward the door like he’d been waiting for this moment since the day we took the Elysium contracts. But I paused.

“Wait,” I said, turning to Harry, lowering my voice. He stopped. “I need to tell you something.”

His brow lifted. “What is it?”

“If anything ever happens — if this goes wrong — there’s a kill switch in the core code.”

Harry blinked. “What?”

“I’ve been working secretly, late nights. I finished it last month. Before all of this. Buried it deep. It’s not in the master schematic, not on any logs.”

“Where is it? Did you put it somewhere safe?”

“Yes. I hid it somewhere no one will ever find it”

He stared at me for a long beat, then nodded. “You really did think of everything.”

Rachel cleared her throat. I hadn’t realised how close she was. Had she heard what I’d just told Harry? “Let’s go. We don’t have all day.”

And with that, we walked into the room. Toward the chairs. Toward the cold NeuroLink Crowns and blinking lights and the nothingness that would

follow. We were ready.

Except not all of us. As Claire settled into her seat, her eyes wide and trembling, she looked toward the door.

Claire's voice cracked. "I think I'm changing my mind."

"You can't," Rachel said flatly, already priming the injectors. "You signed the waiver. You're all in."

Claire tried to stand, but Jean-Marc entered from the hall, hand on her shoulder, pressing her back down.

"Stop," she said, panic rising. "I changed my mind! Paul, I left my journals with Annmarie. She'll give them to you if you want to remember."

She'd done what? But it was too late. The injection hit her vein. Her eyes rolled back

"Wait!" I shouted, angry at what had just happened. Harry called out too, struggling against the restraints that suddenly snapped around his wrists. And around mine.

"Restrain them," Rachel said to Jean-Marc, nodding at Harry while walking towards me.

Harry looked at me, regret in his eyes. "If you remember, wake me up. You know my Safe Word Sequence. I'll do the same for you."

Rachel had pulled a pneumatic injector from her pocket. The needle hit my neck before I could move out of the way. And as the world tilted and the crown lowered, I felt her hand brush mine. Claire's.

Then —

Nothing.

UPLOAD PACKETS 95% COMPLETE

The office was bright, buzzing with the energy of a new launch. Sunlight poured through the wall-length windows of the TechSphere building, catching the chrome accents and glossy screens that littered every desk. It smelled like fresh paint and coffee — new beginnings. Promises.

I was laughing.

Rachel was next to me, her hand resting lightly on my arm as she grinned at whatever dumb joke Harry had just told. We stood by the demo table, half-watching one of the junior engineers flail through a prototype pitch while our eyes met above the chaos and shared the same amused sigh.

“God, I can’t believe they let him near the boardroom,” Rachel whispered.

Harry leaned in. “Victoria likes watching newbies squirm. It’s a real problem.”

We all laughed again, easy and unforced. We looked like a team. Like old friends. Harry and I had moved here from New York after our last contract finished. TechSphere was a good company, a start-up with tons of potential and some investors with very deep pockets.

The project we were working on was something new. Something big. A project I’d begun back in D.C. and brought over, a program that could monitor people’s emotions and behaviours through a series of sensors. The product was aimed at the hotel market, for the business to be able to monitor customers’ preferences and use that data to make their current and future stays better. We didn’t have a name for it, but the tech was beautiful. Elegant. Efficient. Harry and I were being helped by another guy, new-ish. He’d been here before us by a couple of months. His name was Marcus.

“Let’s get working on your latest brainchild,” Rachel had said the day we arrived. “This is going to be huge. I can feel it.”

“Maybe,” I smiled. “I hope so.”

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 97%

The apartment in Midtown was still half-furnished, boxes lining the corners of each room, a slick corporate welcome basket on the kitchen island like a prop in a showroom. I sat on the edge of the sofa, tablet in hand, pretending to read through her CV again.

Haley, her name was. I committed to memory. I was bad with names, for some reason.

She stood in the entryway, a canvas tote bag looped over one shoulder, hair pale blonde, face fresh, posture casual but contained. She was pretty. Not in the glossy, magazine-cover way Rachel was — but subtly. Soft eyes, a curve to her mouth that hovered on the edge of a smile she never quite gave. She wore jeans and a grey T-shirt with the words “clean living” in small letters across the chest.

“You worked private residentials before?” I asked, scrolling idly. I couldn’t focus. Something about her felt oddly... gravitational.

“A few places,” she said. Her voice was low, with a natural calm to it. “Mostly long-term contracts. I prefer regular clients. Easier to take pride in something when you’re part of it.”

I nodded slowly. “Right. That makes sense.”

She smiled faintly, like she’d heard that a thousand times.

My thumb hovered over her name on the screen.

Haley.

But it didn’t feel like that was really it. Something about her eyes, the way she moved, the shape of her hands even — it all stirred something. Not quite memory. Not recognition. Just... a wrongness. A sliver of something familiar you couldn’t name.

She stepped forward just slightly and glanced around the apartment. “You just moved in?”

“Yeah,” I said. “Fresh start.”

Her eyes flicked to mine for a split second too long. “Fresh starts are good. Most people don’t realise how much they need one until it’s already begun.”

I blinked, not knowing what to say to that.

She looked back at the room. “I’ll keep it spotless. Quiet. Won’t be in your way. That’s what you want, right?”

“I guess so.”

She nodded like she understood more than I was saying. “I’ll take good care of you.” There was a pause. “I mean... the place,” she added, her voice softening. “I’ll take good care of the place.”

I didn’t know what to say to that. Again, she had me speechless for some reason.

“Haley,” I said again, like I was trying the name on for size.

“Yep,” she replied, offering her hand. “If you’ll have me.”

I took her hand. Warm. Dry. Familiar. I didn't know why my chest felt tight. Why my fingers hesitated just slightly before letting go.

"Welcome aboard."

She smiled once more, just barely. And when she turned to leave the room, I stood there for a long time, frowning at the empty space she'd left behind.

Not knowing I'd just let the love of my life walk back into my world as a stranger.

But I knew now.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 99%

I was sitting in the window booth at the coffee shop on Lafayette and 9th, the place with the creaky stools and terrible jazz, when I first saw her. She ordered a cappuccino and then knocked it all over her sleeve when her bag slipped. She cursed softly under her breath, flustered, brushing at the stain with napkins. I stood before I even realised I was moving.

"Let me get you another," I said, already signalling the barista.

She gave me this look — half amused, half suspicious. "You don't even know what I was drinking."

"You look like a cappuccino kind of woman." I'd overheard her order but didn't tell her that.

She tilted her head. "And what if I'm not?"

I grinned. "Then I'll have to try again tomorrow."

That was how it started.

Her name was Samantha, but everyone called her Sam. She was sharp, clever, dry-witted. She made me laugh in a way no one had in months. We talked for hours that day. About nothing and everything. Her childhood in Maryland. Her love for photography. The horrible date she'd walked out on last week. I told her about my coding job, about my mother, about how the city was still new to me, even though I'd been here over a year now.

I asked her out that same day. She said yes.

The next few weeks blurred into a kind of warm, easy rhythm. We didn't rush into sex, or even being anything more than friends. Until one night —

Just a flicker now, the memory pulling into focus.

We'd been out for dinner and came back to mine. "Let's go upstairs," I'd managed between kisses. By the time we reached my bed, she was in her sexy black lace underwear, our clothes discarded between here and the front door.

"You're sure?" I asked.

"Very sure," she'd replied, discarding the lingerie and pulling me onto the bed with her.

I felt it all again — the heat of her thighs, the wet slide of her cunt as I fucked her.

And then — something shifted. Not the sensation, not the sex — but her voice.

"Oh god," she groaned, tightening her thighs against my hips. "That feels so fucking good."

That line. The same line someone had said when I went down on her. The same voice.

My breath caught. The image fractured — Sam's face was still there, but something overlaid it. Softer cheekbones. A different angle to her smile. Hair that was longer. Darker.

Claire.

It wasn't déjà vu anymore. It was the truth cracking through the illusion.

"Fuck," I breathed, though the woman beneath me couldn't hear.

My heart pounded. The two women — Sam and Claire — blurring, separating, merging. Two different lives. Two different cities. But one person.

She was Claire.

She had always been Claire.

And now I remembered everything.

UPLOAD PACKETS COMPLETE 100%

MEMORY RESTORATION SUCCESSFUL

Chapter Five

Chapter 5

I woke to the low hum of machines and the sharp antiseptic bite of disinfectant. The first thing I saw was light — muted, blue-toned strips woven into the ceiling above, casting a gentle glow over a room that looked more like a tech-startup crash pad than a medical facility. Cables snaked across the floor in looping bundles. Holographic displays floated mid-air above slim monitors, streaming biometric readouts in a language I barely recognised.

The bed beneath me was hard. A thin sheet clung to my chest, cold and damp—a soft, rhythmic beep pulsed from somewhere above my head. An ECG, I realised slowly. I followed the wires with my eyes — pads stuck to my chest, another cluster coiled around my arm, feeding into a sleek, clear plastic drip pumping something cool and faintly blue into my veins. Sensors had been taped to both temples, the skin there raw and tender.

It felt like I'd been struck by lightning. Every part of my body buzzed, like my nerves were vibrating at the wrong frequency.

I turned my head — and saw her.

Annmarie.

She was sitting on a low stool beside the bed, curled up in a position that looked far too uncomfortable for how peaceful she looked. Her hair had come loose from the braid she'd been wearing, falling across her face in soft, dyed-platinum strands, tinged purplish-blue by the lights above. She wore one of Nadia's hooded sweaters, oversized on her small frame, sleeves pulled down over her hands like she was hiding inside it. Her knees were tucked up to her chest, feet bare, one heel bouncing. She hadn't let go of my hand.

I opened my mouth to speak, but all that came out was a dry croak. My throat burned. My chest ached like I'd been screaming for hours.

Across the room, Nadia was also hooked up to the central console, her eyes flickering rapidly beneath closed lids, lips parted as if caught mid-

dream. Wires trailed from the base of her skull into a black, circular port glowing faintly on the wall behind her.

The Nest, this version of it, was smaller than the New York setup had been, more stripped-down. But it was still unmistakably hers. Every surface was repurposed tech, every object had dual functions. A coffee machine beside an IV station. A filing cabinet with a false drawer open, leading to a biometric scanner. The walls were soundproofed with black foam panels, and two windows had been boarded up, the only light artificial. A mattress had been unrolled in the corner beside a small, empty weapon rack that looked like it belonged in a cyberpunk videogame.

My stomach lurched, clenched. I barely had time to roll sideways before I was throwing up all over the concrete floor — bile and acid and something black streaking the mess. Annmarie jolted awake with a cry, leaping from the stool and reaching for me.

“Oh my God, Paul — Nadia!”

Nadia was already moving, tearing the wires from her temple with a hiss and crossing the space to me in three long strides. She crouched, one hand on my shoulder, the other gently tilting my head back.

“Breathe,” she commanded. “You’re okay. Just breathe through it.”

I tried. It felt like every nerve in my body was short-circuiting. Annmarie was crouched on my other side, rubbing my arm, whispering my name over and over again. I forced air into my lungs, coughed, then gasped again. My head pounded. But I could speak.

“Sam,” I croaked.

They both looked at me.

“She’s Claire,” I said. “Oh my God — she’s Claire.”

The world pitched sideways. My eyes rolled back and everything went black again.

The next time I surfaced, the room was dimmer — Nadia had lowered the ambient lights, and the machines no longer beeped like a warning but hummed like a lullaby. My stomach still roiled, but the worst of it had passed. Annmarie was pacing now, her arms crossed tightly beneath her ample chest, her expression darkened with worry.

“She was in New York the whole time,” she muttered, half to herself. “And I never knew. If I’d taken the time to meet her... I just thought she was some random woman — Sam, Samantha, whatever. I didn’t even check. Fuck, how could I be so stupid? She could be in danger. If they find out who she is...”

Her voice trailed off, full of something between guilt and fear.

I sat up slightly, dragging in a shaky breath. “You weren’t to know, Annmarie.”

She smiled at me when I used her real name, and came to kneel beside the bed again. “You remember me. It worked.”

“It did,” I nodded. “I remember everything.”

I reached for her hand, and she gave it without hesitation, but her fingers were trembling.

I looked at Nadia, her face half in shadow beneath the soft blue glow of the lights. She was watching me quietly, as though she could already sense what I was about to say. My throat tightened. The words didn’t want to come out, but they needed to.

“I remember you too,” I said finally, my voice low. “All of it. Not just what you did for me in New York, but everything you went through before that.”

Nadia didn’t flinch, but her expression shifted — barely. A subtle flicker of something behind her eyes. Pain. Understanding. Bracing herself.

“I was the one who wiped you,” I said. “Harry and I. We... we did it together. And I remember now. We didn’t ask questions. You were just a name. A problem to fix. They told us you were unstable. That you were compromising the project. I believed them. I don’t know what to say.”

Nadia looked down, her hands tightening on the edge of the console. Her jaw clenched, but she didn’t speak.

“I’m so fucking sorry,” I said. “I didn’t know. You were trying to stop them. You were trying to protect people, and I — I erased you. And then... You died. And I thought I’d killed you. It broke me. Harry, too.”

She stood slowly, walked to the table and poured herself a glass of water. Her movements were calm, measured, almost too composed. When she turned back, her voice was quiet.

“So, which Paul are you now?” she asked. “The one who was so ambitious, so loyal to the cause that he’d wipe the memory of someone he didn’t even know? And then stood by while they wiped the memory of his

co-worker? Or are you the Paul that came to his senses and tried to get out?”

“I don’t know,” I whispered, honestly. “While I was... in the NeuroLink Crown, whatever that was, I saw the other two versions of me. The original me and the version of me from New York. We... merged. I think I’m someone new but also... I’m all three of them.”

“I should have warned you about how surreal the reintegration process can be, but we didn’t have time. So, tell me... Are you a danger to us?” Nadia said softly, her body tense as she stared at me. “Or are you going to help us? I need to know who I’m dealing with, Paul Lacuna.”

I sat up straighter, the nausea slowly abating as her words settled in my chest. “I’m me,” I whispered, almost to myself. “I’m no danger to you, Nadia, but none of this would have happened if you hadn’t faked your death.”

She gave a bitter smile, but there was no malice in it. Just tiredness. “I didn’t mean for it to turn out the way it did. You know what it’s like to lose who you are, Paul. I lost myself, too. And when I realised what Elysium had become... when I saw how deep their reach went... what lengths they’d go to... I had to vanish. Faking my death was the only way out.”

“I understand,” I sighed. “You weren’t to know what consequences any of this would have.”

She nodded. “It gave me time. Space. After the first wipe, after I reversed it, I watched from the shadows as they replaced me. I didn’t know you and Harry were. Or Marcus, I just knew they’d brought in a team to build something even worse than what I’d started.”

“I didn’t know,” I said again, the words useless now. “It was just a job. Until it wasn’t.”

She came closer, standing by my side now, softer. “I never blamed you. Not really. I blamed them. For what they did to me. For turning you into something you weren’t.”

Annmarie was silent on the other side of the room, giving us space, though I could feel her presence like gravity.

“I wish I could undo it,” I said. “Everything.”

Nadia leaned in and pressed a hand to my shoulder. “You can’t. But you can finish what we started.”

I sank back against the padded recliner, still feeling the faint aftershocks of whatever Nadia’s tech had done to my nervous system. My stomach

churned with hunger and leftover adrenaline, but I felt steadier now. The torrent of memories had dulled to a manageable hum in the back of my mind, fragments aligning, solidifying. I was starting to feel like myself again — whoever that really was.

“Where are we, anyway?” I asked, my voice rasping like it belonged to someone else.

“We’re still in Boston,” Nadia replied. “South side, near the river. We’re off-grid, safe, at least for now.”

I blinked. “Still?”

“You’ve been out since yesterday evening,” she said, glancing over her shoulder. “It’s morning. Rachel came back late last night. Found the house empty. She found your Guru-Watch, too.”

I sat up straighter, alarm tightening in my chest. “Shit. So she knows?”

“That you’re gone? Yes. That you’re with us? That you’ve got your memories back? No.”

I looked down at my bare wrist. One of the sticky pads from the ECG was still stuck there. “They’ll be looking for me.”

“They already are,” Nadia said flatly. “You’ve officially gone rogue.”

The phrase sat in my stomach like a stone. Rogue. It sounded dramatic, but in a world where your identity and mind could be overwritten, it meant more than just running away. It meant becoming a threat. An anomaly. Something that had to be contained.

I glanced over at Annmarie. She hadn’t said much since the memory sequence had ended. She’d been holding my hand but had moved away and now stood by the kitchenette, making coffee, the soft drip of it the only normal sound in the room. Her eyes were dark, unreadable. I could tell she was trying to give me room to breathe, to collect my thoughts, but our past hung in the air between us — something unfinished.

Nadia moved back toward me and handed me a protein bar and a bottle of water. “You need to eat something. Stabilise your blood sugar. Your body’s playing catch-up.”

I tore into the bar without hesitation, chewing like a man who hadn’t tasted food in weeks. Every bite brought clarity. Then she turned to Annmarie. “Right, I have some things to do. Supplies to fetch. He’s yours for a while. Don’t break him.”

Annmarie smiled tightly and nodded, and I watched as Nadia grabbed her jacket, slung a small case over one shoulder, and disappeared through the

door into the early morning light. She gave me one last look — half-warning, half-reassurance — before shutting the door behind her.

The hush that followed was strange — Annmarie and I, alone together for the first time in years. As the real versions of ourselves, that is. I stood slowly, stretching my legs, and wandered toward the other side of The Nest. “She’s good at this,” I said, running a hand along the edge of a workbench cluttered with circuit boards and neural diagnostic gear.

Annmarie watched me from the corner of the couch, legs drawn up under her. “She’s had to be. They’ve hunted her ever since she escaped New York. This place is the first she’s stayed in for more than a few months. I’ve been staying with her for a while now.”

I explored, following a narrow corridor toward the back, past a curtain strung up haphazardly. Behind it was a compact bedroom — small, but functional. One double bed, a side table, and a small pile of clothes folded in a crate beneath it. The bed was unmade, the covers a tangle of grey and blue, the imprint of two bodies unmistakable. I stared at it for a beat too long.

Annmarie appeared behind me, quiet but close. “You can say it,” she said softly.

I turned to her. She didn’t look away. “You and Nadia?”

She nodded once. “It’s not serious. It just... happened, you know?”

I didn’t answer. I didn’t need to. It didn’t hurt, not in the way it might have, not after everything. But it did tighten something in my chest — not jealousy, exactly. Just the reality of how much I’d missed. How many lives had unfolded in the shadows while mine was being rewritten.

She took another step toward me, arms crossed gently over her breasts, protective. “I was always going to tell you. I don’t want secrets between us, not after everything we’ve been through. When I first looked at the laptop, it had two contact options, Adam and Nadia. Adam’s line was dead, but Nadia answered. I needed to know what had truly happened to you. The crash... it never seemed real. I knew they’d taken you. However, because they were watching Adam’s contact IP, they traced it back. Nadia saved me, got me away from them before they could get to me. So I owe her.”

“I get it,” I said. “You don’t owe me an explanation.”

“I do,” she said, her voice firmer now. “Because I still love you, Paul. Because I never stopped. And I want you to know everything before you decide how you feel about me. Nadia and I have been having sex, but that’s

all it is. Just sex. No strings. Just two women finding some joy amongst the sadness. Some comfort between the danger.”

I stared at her for a long moment. Her face was exactly as I remembered it now — not just in features, but in expression. That stubborn mix of fear and bravery, of vulnerability wrapped in steel. She hadn’t hidden the truth, not even when it might’ve been easier.

And I realised something else in that moment — I loved her, too. I always had.

“It doesn’t change anything,” I said, stepping closer. “I remember who you are. And who we were.”

Annmarie’s lips parted, but no words came. I cupped her cheek, felt her lean into my hand, her breath hitching just slightly as I bent and kissed her.

Her lips moved against mine like she’d been waiting years for this moment — and maybe she had. I felt the tension in her body, not resistance, but restraint, held tightly for too long. She melted against me the moment I deepened the kiss, my hands sliding down her back, fingers splaying at her waist. Her breath caught as I pulled her flush against me, and when her arms wrapped around my neck, something shifted in both of us.

There was no pretending anymore. No confusion. No fog. She wasn’t hidden from me any more.

We fell onto the bed together, the disarrayed covers not bothering us. I rolled on top, kissing her as if I could make up for every second I’d been gone. Her hands were already under my shirt, tugging it up from the back, breath hot against my cheek as she whispered my name.

“Paul...”

She said it like it meant something again. It did.

I tore the shirt off over my head, baring my chest to the cool air, and then helped her out of the oversized hoodie top she wore, leaving her in just a navy blue lace bra. My fingers trembled slightly as I unclasped it, not from nerves but from the moment, being with her, after everything. The bra slipped away, and I paused to look at her. Her curves I remembered, skin I’d kissed so many times and yet never enough. Her breasts were bigger than Sam’s — Claire’s — firm and round, even flattened out slightly as they were from being on her back. My lips found her collarbone, then lower, my tongue flicking against her dark pink nipples that stiffened to the touch, and she gasped, her back arching.

“I missed you,” she murmured, voice ragged. “God, I missed you so much.”

“I know,” I said, kissing lower, slower.

Her jeans came off next, dragged down over her hips along with her panties, a little roughly, my need getting the better of me. She helped, kicking them off as I stood to strip, never taking my eyes off her. She was gorgeous. Her legs were toned, her pussy between them completely bare, shaved, soft and inviting. My cock sprang free, already hard, already aching.

Annmarie reached out and pulled me back to her, legs parting as I settled between them, the warmth of them wrapping around me even before I entered her. She was wet — unbelievably so—and when I slid inside her in one slow, deliberate stroke, we both cried out.

Her legs locked around my hips. Her pussy was so tight. My mouth found hers again. We moved together like no time had passed at all.

For a moment, it felt strange. My old memories hadn’t overwritten the newer ones, in New York, in Boston. They were all there. I was fucking Ashleigh, the housekeeper. I was fucking Haley, my cleaner. I was fucking Annmarie. The excitement of fucking two women I’d never fucked before — plus the joy of fucking the woman I loved.

I thrust into her, frantic at first, months — years — of longing pouring out of us. I drove into her with sharp, deep thrusts, pushing as deep into her as I could, my hands gripping her thighs, then her ass, then her hair as I kissed her harder. She moaned my name into my neck, nails scraping down my back, and every sound made me move faster, fuck her harder.

“Fuck me,” she groaned. “Fuck me, please. Don’t stop.”

I didn’t stop, but I did slow. The sex changed. Shifted into something more intimate.

We held each other like we might disappear from each other again, her fingers tangled in my hair as she whispered things I couldn’t quite catch. I buried my face in her neck, savouring the feeling of her wet, warm pussy as I moved inside her, long and slow, over and over. She clenched around me, her body trembling as she came, and I wasn’t far behind — one more thrust, two, and then I came too, gasping her name into the crook of her shoulder as I filled her with cum.

We stayed that way, tangled, silent, breathless. The kind of silence that said everything. I kissed her forehead as our breathing slowed, and she

smiled against my skin.

“You really do remember everything now?” she asked with a shy smile.

I nodded, brushing a strand of hair from her face. “Yeah. I remember you. I remember this.”

She pressed her palm to my cheek. “Then I’m glad I waited.”

“If you’re wondering why I was hooked up to the console with you, I had to link my implant directly to your Hard Core chip,” Nadia said, gesturing toward the now-deactivated terminal. She’d been out for a few hours, though she hadn’t told me why. When she’d returned, she’d busied herself, helped Annmarie make food for the three of us, before calling us all together to talk.

“I had wondered,” I nodded. “I presume you were monitoring me somehow, as I went through the Safe Word protocol?”

“Correct. The system I used was designed to monitor you in real time. Think of it like... a neural support tether. If the reintegration process caused a seizure or critical memory loop, I could intervene immediately.”

I swallowed, trying to process that. “And? Did you have to do anything?”

“No. It went smoothly,” she said, walking toward me. “All three memory strands — your D.C. self, your New York self, and the Boston construct — they’re stabilised. You’re whole again, Paul. If you feel shit, that’s why. Your brain’s trying to reconcile three different timelines.”

I gave a weak chuckle. “Great. So... normal day then.”

But she didn’t laugh. Her expression tightened.

“I saw everything,” she said. “Your memories. All of it. I didn’t mean to. I wasn’t trying to invade your privacy, but... I found what I needed.”

That sounded ominous.

“What do you mean?” I asked.

She sat on the edge of the equipment case near the bed, her posture more relaxed now, but her voice was quiet. “Elysium kept you close for a reason. You and Harry. They let Claire go because she wasn’t part of the bigger picture. They gave her a clean break, let her drift off into a new identity. But you? They moved you. Curated your life. Watched you.”

Annmarie was still kneeling beside me, silent now. Nadia met my eyes.

“Because you did something,” she said. “To the Fresh Start code. You sabotaged it.”

I nodded, a slow, tired nod that seemed to pull at every memory I’d just regained. “Yeah. I did.”

Her eyes narrowed just slightly. “You coded a kill switch. I saw you tell Harry. And you hid it, right before you were wiped.”

“Correct.” I took a breath, deep and heavy. “A piece of viral code that can bring down all of their systems, including Fresh Start.”

“And do you remember where you hid it?” Annmarie breathed heavily, her hand squeezing mine tightly.

“Of course I do,” I nodded grimly. “I told you — I remember everything. I hid it right under their noses. In plain sight.”

Nadia stood, flexing her back, causing her breasts to jut out of the too-small tank top she was wearing, the nipple-bar piercing visible through the thin fabric. “So, as soon as you’re feeling strong enough, let’s go get it. Let’s shut these fuckers down.”

“Oh, hell yeah,” I agreed. “But we’ll need help.”

“From who?” Nadia tilted her head, the implant on her temple flickering blue.

I took a deep breath, knowing how hard this was going to be.

“From an old friend. Someone I left behind.”

Chapter Six

Chapter 6

The air in New York felt different to how I remembered, laden with recovered memories. The block we pulled up at in particular carried a ghost. If my nervousness showed at all, Nadia didn't seem to notice. She knelt beside a recycling bin in the alley and cracked open a rusted utility access panel like she'd done it a hundred times before.

From her pack, she pulled out a slim, jet-black device. It was a router, she'd told me as she'd installed the ones before. Custom-made. No serial numbers. She wired it in quickly, almost lovingly, fingers dancing over the exposed motherboard like a pianist warming up.

"This is the seventh," she muttered, mostly to herself. "Three in Boston, four here. Once activated, they'll all spoof location data on a ten-minute drift interval. Even if they catch our signal, they won't know which node it came from."

Annmarie stood beside me, arms crossed beneath her jacket, hood pulled tight against the wind. "So we're basically turning New York and Boston into a mirror maze."

"Exactly," Nadia said, smirking faintly. "If Elysium wants to find us, they'll be chasing shadows."

I wasn't really listening. Not properly. My eyes were fixed on the apartment window across the street — her window. Sam's.

The blinds were half-drawn, but not enough to block the silhouette moving inside. A man. Tall, broad-shouldered. He stepped into view for just a second, shirtless, a towel slung low around his waist. I recognised the tattoos, the body.

Raoul was in her apartment. He looked comfortable. Familiar. At home. He moved through her space like he belonged there, and maybe he did. I'd been in Boston for a while. He and Sam must have kissed and made up.

Something pulled at my insides. Not jealousy. Not quite. It wasn't pain either. It was... regret. Plus, there was a weird kind of heat. That slow throb deep in my gut. I imagined her with him — her thighs wrapped around his

waist, her mouth whispering things into his neck, her nails in his back while he fucked her. Not Claire. Not even Sam. Just her. The version of her that she was now in my head, a hybrid of the two. The woman who didn't remember me from D.C. But who I remembered, standing here in the past, watching her suck his cock.

I was hard at the thought, and I hated myself for it.

Annmarie caught the direction of my gaze and followed it. She didn't speak, but she stepped a little closer, her arm brushing mine in a way that grounded me again.

"I'm sure she's okay," she said gently. "You don't need to go in."

"I wasn't going to," I lied.

"We need to check she's okay, but when she's alone. She's either not home right now, or she's with that guy," Nadia added, closing the panel and wiping her hands. "Right now, he might be what's keeping her safe."

I swallowed, my throat dry. "Yeah."

"We'll come back," Annmarie said. "Talk to her when it's safe to do so."

I nodded, but my eyes lingered a second longer before I forced myself to look away.

"Come on," Nadia said, slinging her bag over one shoulder. "Let's go find your old friend. They should be getting off shift soon."

We set off in the van that served as Nadia's mobile base and arrived at our destination just in time. As we parked up, across the avenue, the doors of TechSphere slid open — and there he was.

Marcus hadn't changed. Still dressed like a college librarian, wire-rimmed spectacles sat low on his nose. His eyes landed on me as we got out of the van. For a second, he froze.

Then — he laughed, loud and incredulous.

"Paul?"

"Hey," I waved and smiled, genuinely happy to see a familiar face.

Marcus half-jogged across the sidewalk, dodging a bike messenger and a woman with three miniature dogs. His grin didn't fade for a second.

"Jesus fucking Christ, it *is* you," he said, grabbing my shoulder like he had to physically confirm I was real. "Holy shit. You're okay. You're — " He looked me up and down, taking in the new clothes, the sharper edge to my posture. "You're different."

I smiled, couldn't help it. "Am I? It's great to see you."

“You too. Last I heard, you were in a *coma*, Paul. After the crash. And Harry? They said he moved out of state or some shit due to this illness. It was all a big shock. What the hell happened?”

Annmarie stepped forward and offered her hand. “Hi. I’m Annmarie.”

Marcus shook it instinctively, distracted. “Ummm... hi,” he said, a hint of shyness behind the glasses. His eyes flicked to Nadia next, with a furrowed brow. “You’re friends of Paul’s?”

“Nadia Kowalski,” she said calmly. “And I already know who you are, Marcus Chen.”

He folded his arms, posture stiffening now. The initial joy at seeing me was wearing off, replaced by wariness. “Okay... So, you wanna tell me why the hell you’re all here? I’m getting the feeling this isn’t a social catch-up kind of thing.”

“Not here,” Nadia said. “There’s a café two blocks down. Tiny place, no smart-glass, no cams. We can talk there.”

“Talk?” Marcus eyed the three of us through his slightly dirty glasses. “Talk about what?”

“We just need to talk to you, Marcus,” I said softly. “It’s important. I wouldn’t be turning up out of the blue like this, ambushing you after work, if it wasn’t.”

Marcus hesitated — but curiosity won out. “Fine. I can’t deny I’m happy to see you. You’ve got about twenty minutes before I’ll have to call my girlfriend and tell her I haven’t been kidnapped.”

He led the way, still glancing at me like I might evaporate if he blinked too long. The streets had emptied a little, dusk creeping up the glass of the buildings above us. We kept our heads down. I was wearing a beanie and had put on my sunglasses. Nadia had a Yankees cap pulled low, Annmarie wore her scarf high and her hood low, but Marcus didn’t question it. He didn’t know yet what kind of danger we were in.

The café was half-empty. Old wooden floors, mismatched chairs, a chalkboard menu. Marcus ordered a cortado without asking what anyone else wanted and claimed the booth furthest from the front window. We sat across from him — Annmarie and I on one side, Nadia sliding in alone across from us, blocking him from getting out.

“All right,” Marcus said, hands flat on the table. “Can we talk now? What the hell is going on?”

I looked him in the eye. “I need you to trust me, Marcus. What I’m going to tell you is going to seem crazy. Far-fetched, like something from a science-fiction movie. All I need is for you to listen to me, then I’m going to ask you to do a favour for me, okay?”

“Go for it,” he shrugged, eyeing Nadia alongside him. “But remember. Twenty minutes.”

I dived into it all at once. There was no point in pussy-footing around. I told him everything, even if it was the condensed version. A fast-forwarded reel of Elysium, Fresh Start, the Hard Core chips, the resets. What they’d done to me, Claire, Harry. What they’d done to him. I admitted that it was my fault that he’d been caught in the crossfire, and he had, even though he didn’t know it. I told him about D.C., about New York. About the fake crash, about Rachel. I told him about Nadia’s history and why she was here, working from the shadows to take it all down.

He listened without interrupting. Just sat there, hands folded in front of his coffee cup, blinking occasionally like he was trying to see whether any of this was going to make more sense if he squinted.

“So you’re telling me,” he said after a beat, “That all of this happened, and I just... didn’t know, because I was wiped too? That you, Harry and I were part of a fucking massive corporate brainwipe programme, and yet at TechSphere all this time, I was coding next to you like a goddamn intern?”

“I guess that covers it,” I said. “Sounds crazy, right?”

He gave a long, low whistle, leaned back in his chair, and scratched the back of his neck.

“And you’re living in Boston now?” he asked. “With Rachel.”

“Was,” I corrected. “Not anymore.”

“You broke up?” His eyes flicked up, and then — for a moment — he actually blushed. “That explains it.”

“What?” I asked.

He shook his head. “It’s nothing.”

“Marcus.”

He looked away, cheeks flushed. “I, uh... I sort of know about you and Rachel.”

“You *what*?”

“I saw some videos,” he said, looking like he wanted to sink through the floor. “On a dummy partition of the RoomRecall cloud sandbox. It wasn’t labelled. I was doing a system audit after a security sweep. Saw a flagged

file path and followed it. Next thing I know, I'm watching her in a hotel suite, riding you like a stolen bike." He cringed. "There were other videos too. I closed the tab, but... yeah. Sorry."

"Videos?" I stared at him, confused. "What are you talking about?"

Marcus went quiet. Too quiet. He stared at his cortado, then glanced at me, then at Nadia. Something in his posture shifted, his jaw tightening like a man about to cross a line he wasn't sure he could uncross.

"What is it?" I asked, leaning in.

"You really didn't know," he said, more to himself than to me. "Fuck. I thought you knew."

"Knew what?"

He looked at me again. "You don't know about StayStream?"

"Talk to me, Marcus. I just told you everything. I have no idea what you're talking about."

He sighed. "Fuck. This is the reason I'm inclined to believe your crazy story, Paul. You see, I'm kinda in trouble too. Recently, I found out that RoomRecall isn't just what you think it is. The tech we designed, you, Harry and me—customer monitoring, emotional recognition and feedback? It's real. It's brilliant. But there's another layer. A hidden interface that piggybacks off the recording buffer. I didn't even realise what I was looking at until I started working on that bug you asked me about. The one you couldn't isolate."

My stomach dropped. I hoped he hadn't fixed that.

"Go on," I said carefully.

"There's a shadow system built alongside RoomRecall. A hidden service called StayStream. I found a secret node and managed to log into it covertly. There was no documentation, no logs. It's not an official project on the company books. It's totally dark. A secret prototype, but... it works. It's live."

"And what is it?" I asked. "StayStream? I've never heard of it."

"StayStream records video — not just visual data, but full-body feeds from embedded sensors in the RoomRecall-enabled hotel suites." Marcus took a deep breath before continuing. "Everything the people in the room do, what they feel, hear and see. Every second of it is not only saved and marked with metadata tags, but it's streamed. Live."

Beside me, Nadia stiffened. "You're saying the RoomRecall platform is doubling as a surveillance network? A full-experience surveillance stream?"

“Yes. But it’s worse than that.” Marcus looked pale now. “It’s a voyeurism platform. Not for analytics. For *viewing*. There’s a private access shell built into the code. VIP logins. Subscription tiers. It’s not publicly accessible yet. It hasn’t been launched, but when it is, people won’t just be watching what people do in the selected hotel rooms; they’ll be experiencing it through NeuroLink Crowns. It’s like SkinDeep but real-time. Real people. And they don’t even know.”

Nadia looked like she might throw up. I just stared at him. “You’re telling me this whole time, while I was at TechSphere, I was helping them build a secret live-stream network where people can experience what’s going on in unsuspecting guests’ hotel rooms?”

“Maybe the guests will give their permission, I don’t know. It’s still in testing, from what I can see. I’m sorry, Paul. I thought you were in on it,” he said. “I was going to talk to you about it, but every time I tried to talk to you, Rachel overheard. I tried to pretend it was something to do with the bug that you kept asking me to help you fix, but Rachel cornered me and told me — flat out — that if I kept poking my nose around the system, if I tried hacking my way into private company nodes again, I’d regret it. I’d be dismissed for breaching corporate secrets. She told me to say I’d fixed the bug, whatever it was. Lock everything up, so I had no reason to go snooping either.”

“She threatened you,” Nadia said quietly.

He nodded. “So I had to shut up. I buried the code partition. Took the bugged code of Paul’s and isolated it, like I’d fixed it. Then pretended I hadn’t seen a thing.”

“You said there were other videos?” I asked.

He looked pained. “I can show you. But you might not like what you see.”

“I need them,” I said, a plan forming. “They could help. We can use them. Did Rachel delete them?”

He hesitated, then nodded. “Yes, but not before I backed them all up. As insurance, of course. I’ll email links over. Is that the favour you wanted to ask?”

“No. It’s not that. I had no idea about StayStream. It’s about the bug.” I paused. “The one I asked you to work on? You said you’d fixed it, then locked me out of it.”

“Yeah,” Marcus said slowly. “I isolated it, just to keep Rachel happy. To stop you looking into RoomRecall too deeply, like I had.”

“Marcus, can you get me a copy of that code module? The isolated bug?”

“I guess.” He looked over the rim of his glasses at me with a frown. “But why would you want it now? You don’t even work at TechSphere anymore.”

“Because it’s not a bug,” I said, my voice low. “It’s an encrypted subroutine. I smuggled it out of Elysium, hid it inside the new project I was taking to New York as part of my new life. I genuinely thought it was a bug while I was at TechStream, because I’d forgotten about it with the rest of what I lost during the wipe. I still didn’t know what it was until recently. But now I do.”

Marcus leaned forward, eyes narrowing. “What is it?”

“It’s a kill switch,” I said. “One that can take Fresh Start — and Elysium — offline for good.”

Chapter Seven

Chapter 7

“I heard you,” I said quietly, without looking at her.

The silence that followed was long enough to make me think she wasn’t going to answer. Then, softly, Nadia said, “Ah. Yeah. Sorry about that.”

She was standing by the counter, her back mostly to me, shoulders tense, a glass of water held in both hands like she wasn’t sure if she wanted to drink it or throw it. She was only wearing a black bra and pyjama shorts, and the soft light filtering through the gaps in the boarded windows was just enough to see the faint line of a bruise along her ribs—probably from crawling around under someone’s fire escape installing one of her signal spoofers. Veronica’s apartment was tiny but nice, expensively furnished, well-decorated, like a magazine spread come to life. But so small that there hadn’t been anywhere to hide from the noises coming from the bedroom overnight.

“I didn’t think. The sex just kind of happened,” she said, still not turning around. “Veronica and I haven’t seen each other lately. I didn’t think we made a lot of noise. Besides, Annmarie knows the score between us.”

I pushed the blanket off my chest and sat up on the sofa, stretching the knots out of my back from a night spent pretending I could sleep. “It’s not that you had sex,” I said. “It’s that we heard it. Me and Annmarie. The walls here—”

“I know,” she said quickly, cutting me off. Then she turned to face me. Her expression wasn’t defensive. Just tired. Human. “I know. And I’m sorry. I wasn’t thinking. I just... I wasn’t trying to fuck with you and Annmarie. I should’ve been more careful.”

The regret was real. I could see it in the slump of her shoulders, in the way she kept looking just past me instead of at me. I didn’t need her to explain further. We were all frayed edges and old wounds. None of us always made good decisions. At least she was honest about hers.

“She wouldn’t even lie next to me on the sofa bed after she heard you,” I said, quietly. “Just turned her back and curled up under her coat on the armchair like she couldn’t even stand the thought.”

“Fuck. That’s on me,” Nadia replied, finally looking at me full-on now. “I didn’t mean to mess with her head. You two have been through hell to get here. I don’t want to be the reason it goes off the rails.”

I met her gaze and shrugged, not because I didn’t care, but because I didn’t know how else to answer. This whole journey had been built on secrets, regret, tangled loyalties. The idea that things might get messy now felt like stating the obvious.

“She’s gone out,” I added after a moment. “Didn’t say where. Just said she had something to do.”

Nadia nodded, then crossed the space between us and crouched beside the couch, producing a slim, unlabelled drive from her coat pocket. She handed it to me without ceremony.

“Marcus got this,” she said. “He brought it to me last night while I was out. He didn’t tell you everything. But he told me.”

I turned the drive over in my fingers. It was cold, black, etched with nothing but a faint scuff mark like it had been jammed into a console a dozen times already.

“What’s on it?” I asked.

“The RoomRecall partition. A folder full of unlisted files. Most of them are live experience recordings,” she said. Her voice was calm, but there was a tightness under it now, something restrained. “You can watch them as a real-time video render or... How it was intended to be experienced. But if you choose to watch them, I’m warning you. On there are Rachel’s files. You and her. In a Cerulean hotel. She recorded everything. Plus all the other StayStream test data. Test recordings.”

I didn’t speak. The room seemed to lean in around me.

“Yes, I watched them,” Nadia said, almost too quietly. “While you were asleep last night. I needed to know what this tech really was. I have to say, it’s pretty crazy. If you were a part of coding that... Congratulations. It’s quite something.”

“Fuck, Nadia,” I whispered after a long moment. “So, you saw... Me? And Rachel? How much did you see?”

“Enough,” Nadia chuckled, lightening the mood slightly. But then her smile straightened out a little. “But... It’s more than just seeing. I felt it.

Experienced it. Through her eyes, through Rachel's point of view. Everything she saw, heard, smelled, tasted, felt... I know what it's like to... to have sex with you, because of it. And that's why I'm finding it hard to look you in the eye right now."

That landed like a blow I hadn't braced for. I blinked, trying to process the way she said it—not cruel, not taunting. Just raw. Honest. Maybe ashamed.

"I never intended the tech to be used for that," I managed to murmur awkwardly. "But... Okay. That's got to be weird, being inside Rachel like that. With me. I don't know what to say."

"I know I crossed a line, and I feel bad. I didn't mean to watch more than a few seconds," she added. "But I did. And you're right. It's really fucking weird.."

"It can't have been that weird. You went and had sex with Veronica right after," I guessed.

"Well... yeah," Nadia's eyes finally met mine. "I'm not going to lie. It was... interesting. It's just the same tech as Skin Deep, if you've ever experienced the underground porn stuff that's available for it. But rather than farmed memories, which can be bought and sold, and edited in between, this is live-streamed. It's raw. Unfiltered. It feels... real. Like I was really fucking you."

My cock hardened in my shorts and I adjusted the blanket around my waist to make sure she didn't see. I couldn't stop my eyes from drifting down to her large, firm-looking breasts, half-visible above the cups of her bra. Her shorts couldn't hide the flare of her hips above her pinched waist. Nadia was good-looking, with a great body, as unconventional as she was, and I'd never been more aware of it.

"Anyway," she said, supping the water down quickly, sensing the tension between us. "I need to have a shower and wake Veronica. We've got a lot to get done today."

"Sure," I nodded, relieved that the weird moment had passed. "Before you go... How do I watch these files? Do you have a NeuroLink Crown, or did you patch straight into the—"

I pointed to the neural interface on her shaved temple.

"I have a Crown," Nadia nodded, pointing towards a set of drawers nearby. "Top drawer. Plug it into the mobile terminal." She indicated, this

time to the small PC positioned on the side, a monitor next to it, “You’ll figure it out.”

Then she slipped away, her eyes holding something I couldn’t quite read.

I eased back into the recliner, adjusted the straps, and positioned the NeuroLink Crown over my scalp. The moment it clicked into place, a prickling current raced along the base of my skull—a brief static sting that made my jaw clench. I sucked in a breath. The room faded, and the world dissolved into a lattice of pulsing light.

A waterfall of file thumbnails unfurled before me in a black, infinite space reminiscent of where I’d met my two previous selves. Neon tags, blurred snapshots—hotels, dates, names—Marcus had organised them loosely, but enough for the patterns to shine through. I scrolled. My pulse stuttered when I found it:

CERULEAN ROCKPORT HOTEL—SUITE 1307.

I looked at my hands. They were solid and real. So strange. My finger moved towards the floating thumbnail and selected it.

The world shimmered, and I fell through.

I was there—back in that suite. Riveted to the moment, my own perspective nested inside memory. The bed. The sunlight. Rachel’s dress pooled at her feet, her eyes glittering with anticipation. My own voice sounded in my ears, deep and urgent—a stranger’s, yet familiar. It was real. Utterly convincing.

She held my hips still when I tried to move. I felt her nails digging into my skin, heard myself gasp.

“Stay still,” the recording of her said. “Let me give you your birthday gift properly.”

The sensation of her lips was incredible. I had no idea how my body was reacting back in the real world, but I was rock hard in this virtual space, fully in control and yet not, all at the same time.

She undid her bra, tossing it to the floor and I watched as my hands went straight to her breasts, enjoying the softness of her pale skin, the firmness of her tits, their shape, her hard nipples.

“You’re going to fuck me now,” she’d said then. And she said it now. “Hard. And rough. As rough as you dare. You have my permission.”

Permission? Was she giving me permission to fuck her? Or was that some sort of coded disclaimer to be recorded?

As my body fucked her in the recorded memory, I felt every thrust, every desperate gasp. The sensation was dizzyingly real in a way that made me sure my cock would be hard in the chair. I started to lose myself in the rhythm, the pleasure doubling back on itself, like getting high on old desire. I could taste her, smell her, feel the grip of her thighs around my waist.

Curious, I reached for the interface, a glowing box somewhere just beyond the edge of my vision and—hesitantly—switched the point of view. Suddenly, I was Rachel: on her back—my back—the world filtered through her sensations, every touch dialled to hypersensitive. The angle shifted, my own cock inside her—inside me—thrusting, the fullness, the invasive feeling of a cock inside me, the dizzying swirl of masculine scent and her arousal. It was too much. Too weird. I recoiled, switching instantly back to my original perspective. Being fucked by myself was a step too far.

I blinked hard, heart racing, and brought up the menu again. I knew what happened that night. The grid of files glimmered, daring, promising more. I scrolled to the next date:

CERULEAN HOTEL, BOSTON.

I selected it.

The world rebuilt itself around me—a different room, different time. Rachel was on the bed, naked except for her black heels, her wrists pinned by a large, rough hand. Not mine. And yet it was.

Then I heard his voice—my voice and yet not.

“I’ve fucked your ass so many times. It never gets boring.”

Jean-Marc. I recognised his voice instantly. I watched as the man I was inside flipped over the beautiful redhead in front of him and bent her over. The scene was rough, raw—Rachel moaning into the pillow as Jean-Marc shoved his big cock into her tight asshole and fucked her, hard and fast.

I watched—no, experienced—how it felt to fuck her like that. Rough, deep, without pause or hesitation. When he rolled her over to her back, I gazed down at the face of the woman I loved—still loved, I realised—her pleasure, her submission, the sting as she raked her nails down my chest, the filthy things he whispered in her ear. There was a wildness in her face I’d never seen, a reckless, animal joy. She looked transformed, radiant, almost feral as she begged him for more. Begged him to fuck her harder.

I felt sick, aroused—a cocktail of jealousy, disbelief, and a dark, undeniable thrill threading through my veins. A side of Rachel she'd never shown me, utterly driven by desire. I wanted to wank off, but I couldn't. My phantom hands were lifting her from the bed, holding her on his cock, impaling her, thrusting into her fast until the memory ended with her collapsed across the bed, spent and smiling, Jean-Marc's cum dripping from her ass, oozing down her thighs. The video froze on her flushed, post-orgasmic face, so beautiful and so far from the Rachel I thought I'd known.

I felt sick, angry, impossibly turned on. Rachel's pleasure, her abandon, the way Jean-Marc used her—these were things she'd never let me see, never let me have. The edge in her voice, the way she came for him, again and again, left me shaken and jealous and desperate for more.

I yanked myself out of that file, hands trembling, and scrolled to another.

CERULEAN NEW YORK DOWNTOWN—SUITE 2101.

This time, I chose third-person mode—I wanted some distance, some control. The NeuroLink Crown seemed to tighten its grip, synapses firing as the memory loaded. For a moment, I hovered disembodied—a ghost in the machine—before the world crystallised around me again.

I was in the corner of a lavish hotel suite, golden evening light spilling through floor-to-ceiling windows. The air smelled of bergamot and sex. Across the room, Rachel leaned against the minibar, her red hair loose, lips parted as Jean-Marc whispered in her ear. His hand slid up her thigh, hiking her skirt as she moaned gutturally—another sound I had never heard from her. Uninhibited. Wild.

Victoria Nash entered from the bathroom, her ash-blonde hair cascading over a silk robe barely tied at the waist. “Enough fucking around,” she purred, catching Jean-Marc's gaze. “This is a workplace, not a hotel room. We have a schedule to keep.”

I was confused for a moment, this definitely was a hotel room, and a classy, expensive one at that. Then I realised they were roleplaying.

Rachel's breath hitched as Jean-Marc spun her toward Victoria, his palm firm on the small of her back. “You heard the boss.”

My phantom heart lurched. I moved closer, my boots silent on the imaginary carpeted floor, observing like a spectre cursed to witness his own undoing.

Victoria's robe slipped from her shoulders and pooled at her feet, revealing a body honed by hours in the gym. Her paid-for breasts hung

perfectly, tipped with small, stiff, pink nipples. She traced Rachel's jawline with a manicured nail. "You're very eager for this promotion, aren't you, Miss Gass?"

Rachel nodded, cheeks flushed. "Yes, Ms. Nash."

"Then earn it."

Jean-Marc grabbed Rachel's hair, tilting her head back as Victoria claimed her mouth. My gut twisted—not at the kiss, but at Rachel's willingness, her lack of objection. Her hands fumbled between Victoria's thighs, finding her waxed pussy, desperate to please, while Jean-Marc undid his belt with his free hand.

"Look at her," Jean-Marc growled, pressing against Rachel from behind. "She needs this promotion so bad, she'll do anything. The desperate slut."

Victoria broke the kiss, smirking. The two of them disrobed Rachel as she stood there submissively. Within a minute, she was naked before them, her body on full show to her boss.

"Now, shove your cock down her throat," Victoria ordered Jean-Marc after taking a long moment to enjoy the sight of her, to feel her breasts and the wetness between her thighs. "Let's see if she chokes. If she does, she fails the interview."

My spectral form vibrated with rage as Jean-Marc finished getting naked, then forced Rachel to her knees before guiding his rock-hard length into Rachel's mouth. Her eyes watered, but she took him deeper, throat working around his girth. Victoria watched, fascinated, before trailing fingers down Rachel's spine.

"Good girl," Victoria murmured, walking away and spreading herself across the king-sized bed. "Now show me what else that mouth can do."

The scene unfolded with brutal efficiency—Rachel servicing Victoria with trembling focus, her tongue lapping eagerly at her investor's tight-looking pussy lips, Jean-Marc looming behind, hands roaming on my fake-wife's body possessively. I circled the bed, torn between fury and fascination. The blood pounded in my nonexistent ears as Jean-Marc mounted Rachel from behind, her cries muffled against Victoria's thigh as he took her roughly, in her pussy, this time.

Victoria's laugh cut through the haze. "*Pathetic*. You're going to let him ruin your cunt for a corner office?"

Rachel moaned, the sound equal parts shame and euphoria. "Yes—*fuck*—yes—"

“Did I say you could stop licking my cunt?” Victoria asked, her voice hard. “Fucking luck it. Lick my clit, make me cum if you want this position.”

My vision blurred. The memory glitched, overlaying fragments of Claire’s journal entries—Jean-Marc’s hands on another woman, another betrayal. This man had fucked two of my wives. I reached instinctively to tear the Crown off, but the program held me captive, forcing me to watch as Rachel arched, shuddering, between them.

“Look at her,” Jean-Marc sneered, hips snapping. “Same stupid ‘O’ face Claire used to make when she came on my cock.”

The words shattered the illusion. I stumbled backwards, the suite dissolving into static. I yanked the Crown off, hurling it across the room. My hands shook, sweat cooling on my skin as the afterimages burned—Rachel’s pleading eyes, Jean-Marc’s triumph, Victoria’s cold enjoyment.

My cock was painfully hard, straining against my shorts, pure need spiralling up through me even as shame burned hot under my skin. I stumbled from the chair and made it to the bathroom just in time, slamming the door behind me. I barely got my shorts down before I was pumping my cock, trying to banish the images that were burned into my brain—the sight of Rachel on her knees between Victoria’s thighs, Jean-Marc fucking her, the sounds, the smells, all as real as if I’d actually been there.

Within seconds, I was gasping, hips jerking forward into my hand as release hit me hard and fast. I came with a force that left me shuddering, ropes of cum splashing into the shower. The relief was instant and overwhelming, but the guilt hit just as hard. Dirty, abashed, I ran some water to wash away the cum, cleaned myself up, splashed my face with cold water, wishing I could somehow scrub the memories away.

When I emerged from the bathroom, zipping up, Nadia was already waiting. She leaned against the kitchen counter, arms folded across her chest, watching me with a knowing look that made it clear I hadn’t been as quiet as I’d thought.

“Feel better?” she asked, one eyebrow arched.

Heat crept up my neck. I cleared my throat, looking everywhere but at her. How long had she been standing there? “Yeah, I—sorry. That was... intense.”

She smirked, eyes drifting down to my waist for a second. “*Skin Deep* doesn’t just get under your skin—it gets *in* it.” She tilted her head, almost

amused. “You should have seen what Veronica was like after her first time with one of those live feeds. She was the one who convinced me to try Skin Deep, but this... *StayStream*... it takes it to another level.”

I tried to shrug it off, but my cheeks still burned. “Yeah. I wasn’t expecting it to be... that real.”

“Do you want to talk about it?” Nadia asked, her tone softening, almost compassionate. “What you saw? I should have warned you, but I worried you wouldn’t want to watch it if you knew it was... her cheating on you like that.”

“I don’t know how to feel,” I admitted, voice quiet. “Watching her... with them. With *him*. Do you know he fucked Claire too?”

She nodded, then touched my shoulder, a brief press of her fingers that was more comfort than flirtation. “If it helps, none of them are getting out of this clean. I’m going to make sure of it. Those videos—recordings... They’re our ace in the hole. You know that, right?”

I nodded, managing a crooked smile, the tension between relief and regret still thrumming through me. She was right. The little hard drive that Marcus had filled with those files was the last piece of the arsenal that we needed to get revenge.

Nadia and I were still on the couch, forgotten mugs of coffee cooling on the table. We’d been working out our plan for a while when the front door creaked open. Annmarie entered first, her eyes wary but bright, like she’d just finished convincing herself that coming here was brave and necessary. She wasn’t alone.

Beth followed, her blonde hair cut shorter than I remembered, eyes rimmed red, an anxious look on her face. She paused just inside the doorway, arms folded, glancing around nervously until she saw me. Then she looked over her shoulder, and I saw her—my mother. She looked smaller than I remembered, shoulders drawn in around her as if her satchel were a shield. When she saw me, a dam broke in her face—pride and worry dissolving into fierce love.

“Paul,” she said, barely more than a whisper.

I was on my feet before I had time to think, crossing the room in two strides and gripping her tight. She clung to me, trembling, as if trying to

hold back everything unsaid between us.

“I thought I’d lost you,” she breathed. “I wish I hadn’t lied to you. I had no choice. But I thought—I really thought—”

“It’s okay. I’m here,” I managed. “I’m so sorry I walked out the last time —”

“Don’t say sorry. We’re together now. That’s all that matters.”

Beth stepped in next, offering a hug that was quick but genuine. “You look different,” she said, studying my face like she was still searching for the old me.

“You haven’t changed,” I said, giving her a smile, truly happy to see her. “Apart from your hair.”

“Is it true?” she asked, her dark eyes searching mine, full of hope. “Harry? He’s not sick? He didn’t leave of his own accord?”

“I’ll fill you in later,” I nodded.

Behind her, Veronica slipped in—tall, dark-haired, graceful and radiating a kind of quiet assurance. She seemed the least nervous of us all. I made a mental note to find out who she really was. Her steadfastness was impressive. Who was she really? She exchanged a brief look with Nadia, then moved to close the door and check the locks, always the sentinel.

And then, lagging last, lugging a battered backpack, was Marcus. He looked tired, dishevelled like he’d slept rough. He stood, alternating his weight between one foot and the other, waiting awkwardly at the edge of the group, uncertainty on his face until I caught his eye and gave him a nod. He managed a grateful, lopsided smile and slipped further into the room, pushing his wire-rimmed glasses further up his nose.

Annmarie broke the silence, practical as ever. “They wanted to help. Or at least not to be alone someplace, waiting for Elysium to knock on their door. I wanted to make sure everyone was safe. We need all the help we can get, Paul.”

I nodded, taking in the room. “No one’s safe on their own anymore. What about Claire? Samantha?”

Anmarie shook her head. “I’ll admit, I’m worried. Her apartment was empty. Her partner wasn’t there either.”

“Fuck. Hopefully, she’s safe. Not on their radar,” I sighed. I looked at the group who were standing in the middle of the room now, looking at Nadia and I, waiting. “Thank you for coming. We’re going to get out of this. We have a plan.”

Beth squared her jaw, defiant. “If Harry’s in danger, I’m not sitting out. I want in.”

I smiled at her. Beth was a special woman. Perhaps, if things had worked out differently...

My thoughts were interrupted as Nadia leaned forward from her spot at the worktable, her purple hair brushing her cheek. “Okay, listen up. We’ve set up seven secure nodes across two cities. This place is dark—Marcus will assist from here as we make our move. The rest of us will either run a distraction through those remote router nodes, or will be in the team that breaks into Elysium.”

No one moved at the mention of breaking into the headquarters of the corporation that had ruined our lives. That was encouraging. Veronica turned to Marcus, her voice calm, “I’ve reinforced the exits. No one’s getting in here who shouldn’t.”

Marcus cleared his throat and finally spoke, his voice soft but certain. “I got it, Paul.” His hands shook as he zipped open his backpack, revealing drives, notepads, and a tangle of cables. He reached inside and passed me a simple USB drive. “I got the kill switch code. I brought everything I could. If we’re going to fight back, I want to be here for it. I want back what they took from me.”

I felt Annmarie slip her hand into mine. My mother stepped back, eyes shining, pride folding over her worry. Beth nodded quietly, her resolve matching the others. Nadia lifted her chin, and Veronica braced herself by the door.

Before anyone could say more, Nadia’s console chirped a harsh warning. She spun to the screen, her fingers dancing over the keys, eyes narrowing. “Trace ping,” she announced. “Adam’s old contact node. It could be a trap, but don’t worry, we’re untraceable.”

She pressed a key, and a moment later, the monitor next to her flickered. Eleanor Gass’s face swam into focus, backlit by Elysium’s sleek boardroom.

“Ah. You’ve answered. I hope you have a visual.” Eleanor’s voice was even and dangerous. “You’ve made things complicated, Paul. I don’t know what you’re doing, but this can all be resolved.”

She waited for a moment.

“You don’t want to talk? Fine. I can see that you’re connected. Watching.”

She smiled coolly, stepping aside. Rachel stood near the back, arms crossed, her eyes staring at the camera, a dark look I didn't recognise on her face. Standing next to her was Jean-Marc, his expression all seriousness. And in the foreground, between them and Eleanor, was Sam. No, Claire. Bound to a chair, blinking, terrified.

"Nadia, if you're behind this, which I suspect it is," Eleanor shook her head. "You need to stop this ridiculous rebellion of yours. And Paul... Give yourself up."

My heart was beating so hard I thought I might throw up.

Eleanor looked over her shoulder at Claire—Sam. "Nadia. Paul. Report to the Boston office. We won't hurt you. We just want to talk. If you don't... she forgets everything."

The screen went black.

For a long moment, no one breathed. Then I turned to Nadia, voice steel-edged. "We don't have as much time as we thought."

"You want to do this tonight?" She pushed her purple hair out of her eyes and smiled grimly at me.

I nodded. "We're done running."

Annmarie tightened her grip on my hand. Beth, Marcus, my mother, Veronica—all of them looked at me, ready.

I faced them, met their gazes—our strange, makeshift family, every one of us changed by Elysium and the secrets we'd tried to bury. Then I faced the darkened screen.

"They want a fight?" My voice was low, final. "Let's show them what we're made of."

Chapter Eight

Chapter 8

The van stank of last-minute thrown-together soldered circuitry and adrenaline. Nadia crouched between two server racks, her neural implant casting jagged blue shadows across the gear-strewn floor. Her fingers danced across three keyboards at once as holograms of Elysium's network architecture rotated above us like digital storm clouds.

"Marcus hits their Boston servers in three minutes," she said without looking up. Purple hair fell across her face as she nodded toward Annmarie. "Check the signal repeaters. Last thing we need is losing comms in Elysium's dead zones."

"Can you hear me?" Marcus's voice came through the earpiece tucked into my left ear. "Boston servers are hitting now. New York in four minutes."

"Gotcha," Nadia replied, looking at me and Annmarie to make sure our comms were working too. I nodded, as did Annmarie, who moved with methodical precision through the cramped space, her leather jacket creaking as she tested two devices on the worktop. "Scramblers are hot. Are Veronica's team ready at the secondary site?"

"Locked and loaded." Nadia's eyes flicked to me. I'd found out that Veronica was an ex-cop. That explained a lot, her poise, her confidence. "You remember the plan? The kill switch is pre-loaded, ready to go?"

I touched the base of my skull where the chip hummed. I grinned. "It's all in here."

Then a news alert caught our attention, and we turned our eyes to the small TV built into the back of the driver's seat behind us. The message we'd been waiting to see—leaked to several journalists by my mother, using an anonymous VPN set up by Marcus back at Veronica's house—scrolled across a red banner on CNN news.

BREAKING: Elysium CEO Eleanor Gass's daughter, Rachel Gass Implicated in Corporate Sex Scandal. Memtech investor Victoria Nash

involved amid rumours swirling that her and Cerulean Hotels are running a live sex streaming service without guests' knowledge.

Grainy footage of Rachel and Victoria Nash played on loop, their faces blurred but unmistakable.

“Showtime,” Annmarie murmured, strapping a compact pulse pistol to her belt.

Then Adam’s comms bead chirped. Rachel’s ID flashed onscreen.

“Don’t,” Nadia warned, but I’d already accepted the call.

Rachel’s face appeared on-screen, unmoving, an avatar. “Paul, please—they’ll kill me if you release those files!”

“You should’ve thought of that before fucking him,” I murmured to myself, not opening comms or camera at my end, watching her wait for a reply.

“Paul? Paul, please—”

Rachel’s voice—raw, desperate—echoed through the van. Nadia’s eyes narrowed, focused on me, her neural implant pulsing crimson. I shook my head. I wasn’t falling for it.

“I know you can hear me.” Rachel’s face materialised, replacing the static avatar, tear-streaked and pale. “They’re making me do this. I never wanted to hurt you.”

Annmarie snorted. “Bullshit. She’s stalling.”

“The Paul I love wouldn’t abandon me,” Rachel whispered, her lower lip trembling. “Remember Boston? The harbour? You promised we’d always protect each other.”

“Those memories were fake,” I said aloud, reminding myself of the fact as much as anything.

“They want you to reply,” Nadia explained. “They’re desperate, looking for a trace. Even if you did reply, it wouldn’t work. We’re dark.”

“Paul. I love you,” Rachel implored. “Please, pick up. I know you can hear me.”

Annmarie moved, reaching across and severing the connection with a violent keystroke. “Fuck off, bitch.”

Then the lights in the van flickered, as did the lights of the building in front of us, Elysium’s New York headquarters. They’d tried sending us to Boston, but it hadn’t worked. Nadia had traced Eleanor Gass’s call to here, unless they’d somehow duped us. We’d find out soon enough.

“That’s Marcus’s DDoS tsunami,” Nadia said, her face showing genuine admiration. “Impressive. He’s pretty good for a corporate nerd.”

I looked at a map of the city on a small device sitting on the worktop, one of those that Annmarie had switched on—and saw citywide blackouts flickering across the tracking map. Elysium’s firewall percentages plummeted.

“Let’s go!” Nadia slapped the roof twice. “Twelve minutes until backup systems engage!”

Annmarie kicked the rear doors open, night air rushing in and prickling the hairs on my skin. “We’re really doing this?”

“Yes, we fucking are,” Annmarie grinned at me. “If we end up in prison, or worse, I always loved you, Paul Lacuna. You know that, right?”

“I love you too,” I nodded, her words pulling at my heart strings before pulling myself together. I picked up my NeuroLink Crown and hitched it over my shoulder. “You sure this works?”

Nadia pressed a fresh biometric patch to my neck. “It will.” She paused, her smirk fading. “Just don’t die before we get to use it.”

It was as deadly and dangerous as she implied. This was the biggest risk I’d ever taken, complete madness, when you looked at it. But it was the only option we had. I’d lost so much—we all had—this was all we had left.

We moved in sync—around the side of the building, staying in the nighttime shadows.

Marcus’s voice crackled through comms: “Mainframe access will be available in ninety seconds. Watch for cameras. I’ll try to disable them as we head through. Go.”

Elysium Tower’s side service entrance swallowed us whole, Nadia and Marcus’s stolen codes bypassing scanners with ease. The concrete stairwell reeked of industrial cleaner and fear as we took the steps two at a time, Nadia and Annmarie’s boots echoing behind me.

Floor 3 held the service elevator, which was the only one that would take us to the basement. The doors opened. Empty. A collective sigh of relief from the three of us.

The door hissed open to a white hallway, endless and silent. Which way? Left or right?

“Okay,” Marcus’s voice was distorted, barely audible. “Cameras are down, but we’re racing against the clock here. Our DDoS attacks won’t last

forever, they'll shut them down soon."

"Which direction, Marcus?" Nadia asked, her eyes scanning both ways. "We're in the basement, service elevator entrance."

But Marcus's reply didn't come. The earpieces crackled, something unintelligible

"We don't have time. Let's split here," Annmarie murmured, checking her gun. "Nadia, you go left. Paul and I will go right. Hopefully our comms will still work down here.."

I nodded, and we moved, staying close to the wall until we reached a door with a small glass window. Locked. I took the card Nadia had given me, projecting a glowing green scan of a palm onto the biometric pad, and the door's lock clicked open—then the door slammed forward and a blur of motion knocked me off my feet, slamming me against the wall so hard the breath flew from my lungs. One second, I was reaching for the door's handle, the next Jean-Marc's forearm was across my throat, pinning me, his other hand catching Annmarie's wrist as she drew her weapon.

He grinned, his face inches from mine. "Bonjour, mon ami." He slammed my head back, spots sparking behind my eyes. "You made a mistake coming here."

Annmarie twisted, bringing her pistol to bear, but Jean-Marc was too fast; he wrenched her arm up, the gun clattering across the tiles. He drove his knee into my stomach—hard enough to fold me in half—then turned, gripping Annmarie by the throat in one massive hand.

"You think you're heroes?" he growled, glaring at both of us as I gasped for breath. "You're pawns. That's all you are. Pathetic."

Annmarie spat in his face, blood on her lips. He wiped the bloody spittle from his cheek, then backhanded her. She crashed into the opposite wall, sinking to the floor, dazed but not unconscious.

Anger surged through me, and I tried to get up, but the moment I was on my feet, his hands closed around my neck. The edges of my vision went dark.

And then Nadia appeared at the far end of the hallway, boots pounding against the floor as she ran towards us, eyes wild beneath the spill of purple hair. She didn't hesitate—just crossed the distance in a sprint, jamming something against Jean-Marc's exposed neck before he could turn to see who was approaching.

He stiffened, lips drawn back from his teeth. There was a faint hiss, and a blue light flickered across the implant gun Nadia held there.

“Back off,” she hissed, pressing the device deeper. “Feel that? That’s a Hard Core chip. Custom rigged. You mess with us, I fry your neural pathways right now. One twitch—one bad thought—and your mind goes dark for good.”

Jean-Marc froze, eyes darting from Nadia’s impassive face to mine, then, as she stepped back, to the pulsing lights of the small black panel in her hand. He rubbed at the back of his neck, a small smear of blood on his hand when he looked. A bead of sweat rolled down his jaw as he did the calculation. His hands tightened on my throat. I could barely breathe.

Annmarie found her feet, blood at the corner of her mouth, stun gun retrieved and aimed at his chest. “Try anything. I dare you.”

Jean-Marc slowly released his grip. “You bluff.”

She smiled grimly. “Maybe. Want to find out?”

He stepped back, hands raised, the menace barely contained. Nadia kept her finger poised over the panel in her hand, not breaking eye contact. “You’re going to help us finish this. If you don’t, I press a button and you get to find out how many memories I can burn in two seconds, and we work out how to do this alone.”

He hesitated, then nodded, breathing hard.

Annmarie gave me a hand up. My ribs ached, my vision still swimming, but the adrenaline was a wave I could ride. Nadia flashed a quick look at me—my nerves were shot, my heart was thumping, but it was almost as if she was enjoying herself.

“Let’s move,” she said. “We’ve got the ugly part handled. Now let’s go find Claire.”

What Jean-Marc didn’t know was that it was, indeed, a bluff. A plan we’d come up with last night, while finishing our preparations. We’d figured that him—or Rachel, or someone else—might try to stop us. I took a deep breath. From here, everything was at risk. But all I could think—bluff or not, Nadia had just saved our lives.

In my ear, Marcus’s voice crackled: “You’re back. You went dark for a moment. Okay, you’re nearly at the lab. Go, now. I’ll hold the alarms—but you’ve only got a few minutes.”

We moved quickly, keeping Jean-Marc ahead of us, Nadia’s finger never leaving the fake chip controller, making him direct us to the mainframe and

where Claire was being held. We crept down the corridor, every nerve alive to the possibility of more guards or some last-minute trap. My heart hammered as we reached our destination—glass-walled, cold, like I remembered. The place I'd erased Nadia. I shared a look with her, but she shook her head. This wasn't the time for regrets.

Inside, Claire was strapped into the same medical chair, her arms and legs secured by padded restraints, a medical monitor beeping steadily at her side. Her eyes fluttered—she seemed drugged, head lolling, hair falling across her pale cheeks. My breath caught. Was it too late?

Rachel stood nearby. She looked up as we burst into the room, her lab coat thrown hastily over street clothes, a tablet clutched white-knuckled in one hand. She froze when she saw Jean-Marc indicate towards Nadia's control device, and for a heartbeat, shock and fear warred across her face.

"What the hell is going on?" she demanded, her voice cracking. "Jean-Marc—"

"Drop the tablet, Rachel," Annmarie snapped, gun raised and unflinching. "Step away from Claire. Now."

Rachel hesitated, then took a single step back—not enough to really matter, but enough to show she'd read the situation.

"Paul," she said, turning her attention to me, voice going soft, almost pleading. "I know you think I'm the villain. But you don't understand what's happening, what they're making us do. This—everything—wasn't my choice." Her eyes flicked to Jean-Marc, whose jaw clenched.

"You manipulated me. You rewrote my mind," I said, my fists tightening at my sides. "You made me love you. Is that what you tell yourself? That you're a victim too?"

Rachel's mask slipped. "If I hadn't, they would have wiped you completely. You'd be a shell. I saved you more than once, Paul. I—"

Something changed on her face, a look of desperation in her eyes and she took a step forward but Annmarie moved even faster, striking Rachel hard across the face with the butt of the gun. Rachel staggered back, hitting the wall, the tablet clattering to the floor. In the same moment, Jean-Marc twisted, catching Nadia off guard—a punch driving into her side, dropping her with a grunt. Annmarie spun, gun swinging, but Jean-Marc lunged first, knocking her into the glass. It cracked with a spiderweb pattern, then exploded, splinters flying everywhere, and she slumped to the floor.

Jean-Marc rounded on me, teeth bared. He was on me in two strides, rage and muscle. A fist to my jaw sent me spinning. I hit the floor hard, seeing stars even as I tried to get up. He kicked me in the ribs, once, twice—pain exploded through my entire body.

Nadia crawled towards her controller, clearly hurt, dragging herself across the cold tile. A trail of blood smeared across the floor, and suddenly I noticed the knife in Jean-Marc's hand. He stared down at her, pausing to sneer. "You want to try your little trick again, girl?" But it was all the time I needed—I slid across the floor, grabbing the control panel from where it had fallen from Nadia's hand, holding it up, thumb poised over the button.

"Back up," I wheezed, "or I fry your memory for good."

He laughed, stepping forward. "You're bluffing. There is no—"

I knew it wouldn't work, but maybe he'd at least pause, giving me a moment to work out a plan. I pressed the button.

Jean-Marc froze mid-step. His mouth dropped open, eyes going wide, confusion morphing into terror. He staggered, hands clawing at the back of his neck, then collapsed in a heap, body twitching as a light on the device in my hand flashed blue and then turned a solid red.

The silence was total except for my ragged breathing and Claire's shallow, drugged breaths. Nadia whimpered, clutching her side. Annmarie was still, unconscious or worse, and Rachel slumped against the wall, out cold.

I stared at Jean-Marc's twitching body, my chest heaving. I'd pressed the button as a bluff, a desperate gambit—Nadia had told me it was just a shell, an empty device made to look genuine. But the way he collapsed, the way his eyes rolled back and his mouth worked soundlessly... it was real. I'd seen enough to know the difference. For a heartbeat, guilt and horror flooded me. Had I just killed him? Or just wiped his mind clean, left him a drooling husk?

My hands shook as I tried to get my breath back. "Nadia..." I croaked, voice raw. "You said this was fake."

She managed to get to her feet, grimacing, one hand pressed to her bleeding side. "You'd never have let me use it," she whispered, looking as horrified as I felt. "Besides, I didn't think it would actually work."

The room pulsed with red warning lights and the faint, insistent wail of distant alarms. I staggered to my feet, the world tilting. I made it to Claire's

chair, my hands shaking as I fumbled at the restraints. “Sam. Claire—please. Come back to me...”

Marcus’s voice snarled in my ear, frantic. “Paul! Nadia! You’ve got two minutes, tops. The building’s waking up—firewalls, physical security. You need to deploy now or it’s over.”

Nadia pulled the NeuroLink Crown from my shoulder, thrusting it into my hands. “Now or never, Paul.” She staggered to the access panel, popping it open with fingers slick with blood.

I strapped the cold metal device to my head. Nadia plugged the interface cable into the jack on the back wall, glancing up at me with wide, pain-filled eyes. “Ready?”

“Do it,” I breathed.

She flicked a switch, and the world snapped away. For a split second, I was aware of Annmarie somewhere behind me, Nadia leaning against the wall just out of reach, her breaths pained—but then everything blurred, pixelated, dissolved.

Once again, I was floating in the darkness. The infinite black of the Elysium system spilled all around me—webs of code, branching corridors of encrypted data. Nadia’s presence flickered beside me, a blue-tinged ghost, her Hard Core implant an older version.

“Go,” her voice echoed, both in my head and in my ear. “I’ll try to bypass the security for you, then I’ll find Harry, Adam and Claire’s memory backups and restore them. I hope Veronica and Beth have found them in the real world and are ready for when they wake up. You need to find the kill switch module. Marcus preloaded the code onto your chip. Find it, Paul. Trigger it if you can. We’ll hold the door as long as we can.”

Outside, alarms shrieked—I sat down, so I wouldn’t fall as I dived fully into the VR environment of the Crown. Then I hit the ‘Execute’ button glowing in the menu before me and the real world completely disappeared, all sensations, lights and sound replaced by the darkness.

For a moment, I remembered everything again. Harry, me, Marcus working together in the D.C. Elysium building. I’d helped create this place. Could I do this? Could I undo it, destroy my life’s work?

“Paul.”

Nadia’s voice crackled in my comms, yanking me back from memory and regret to the stark, sterile present—my mind once again inside Elysium’s black infinite void. I floated beside her in the data stream, the code

whispering all around us, Elysium's master system sprawled open like a living map.

"Paul—focus!" Nadia's voice repeated, on the edge of panic, her avatar blue-tinged and flickering slightly. "Their security protocols are patching as we speak. We're almost out of time."

I shook off the confusion, pushed the self-doubt to the back of my mind. I reached for the kill switch module—the sequence Marcus had pre-loaded. It pulsed, a red node in a sea of blue code floating around me. "I'm here. I see it," I said, my own voice echoing oddly in this digital nowhere. "I'm going to try."

I located the socket where the kill switch code had to be inserted, which would decrypt and deploy it, but the moment I tried to slot it into place, a blunt, invisible force shoved me back. The system screamed an error across my vision in bold yellow letters.

ACCESS DENIED. CODE MODIFICATION UNAUTHORISED. INCORRECT HARD CORE VERSION.

I tried again. It wouldn't socket. I hit a debug routine, which quickly returned an error code and message. Wrong Hard Core firmware version.

Fuck.

The firmware upgrade they'd given me during the second wipe—they'd locked me out. My chip wasn't enough. I tried to override the error, but again, the system blocked me. Our whole plan, dead in seconds.

"Nadia," I gasped, "I can't deploy it. They upgraded my chip. I'm running a new version, it's not compatible with the code I wrote. My permissions are revoked. They patched me out."

"No, no, no," she moaned, panic flooding her words. "There has to be another way." I felt her presence darting through the code, searching, desperate. "Paul—they're breaking in. You need to bail. I've restored Marcus, Harry and Adam. I'm working on Claire now. I just have to unlock her from the second wipe protocol they were about to run on her. You can go now. Get out—"

But then figures began to resolve around me—ghosts conjured up by the system as Nadia freed them. Three Harrys materialised first: the jokey, grinning D.C. version, a tired New York one, and a haunted Boston Harry. Two Adams flickered into existence, overlapping, one with stubble, one clean-shaven and intense. I couldn't help but smile at seeing the five men as they looked down at their bodies, floating in the darkness, cyan-coloured

code all around them. Then two versions of Marcus manifested, either side of me, making me jump, and the blue code scattered around us.

I stared, speechless, the grin still present as the Harrys shared a look, a silent, heavy acknowledgement passing between them. Harry had helped me build this place. He knew what was happening. What he had to do. But not Adam. The two versions of him seemed lost, frightened, until Nadia's digital presence moved to them, soothing, taking their hands and pressing them together, helping him merge. As I watched, still helpless to deploy the kill switch, one version of Adam faded into the other, then they both disappeared. The two copies of Marcus did the same, both pushing their wire-framed glasses up their noses at the same time, something that made me laugh softly, despite the gravity of the situation.

"Paul," two of the Harrys spoke together, at the same time. The Boston version stayed quiet, wringing his hands anxiously. "Thank you. You risked everything for me. If we don't make it out of here, I hope you forgive me—us."

Then those two grinned, and before he could pull away, they took the hands of their third copy. Their forms glowed and blurred, fusing into a single figure—one who gave me a last sad-sweet smile before he too vanished into the nothingness.

Nadia's panic broke through again: "Paul, we're out of time! We have to go. The system's almost back online. If we don't bail—"

Then Claire appeared—her D.C. self, dark-haired, dark-eyed. Wearing the red dress I'd bought for her. The one where she met Adam. Fuck, she was beautiful. My heart ached at the sight of her.

"Paul?" she said, her eyes widening. "You're here."

Then the Sam version of her emerged out of the black, arms crossed defensively, wearing a white T-shirt and jeans, her hair streaming behind her as though some unfelt wind blew through the void.

"What's happening?" she asked me, her eyes moving to Claire. "You're..."

"Me," Claire replied, their voices blending perfectly.

"Paul. Get out. Now." Nadia's blue aura was fading. She was disappearing.

I ignored her, locking eyes with Claire. "You have to merge," I told her, voice aching. "I tried to shut this down, but I can't. Touch Sam's hand. You'll become one. Then we can get out of here."

“I know,” she whispered. The Sam version hovered close, uncertainty on her face. Claire looked at her for a second, sadness on her face. Then she turned to me. “Your Hard Core chip. They upgraded it. But Paul—my chip... It’s still the original version. I heard you when you told Nadia your chip can’t do it. Mine can. Use me. Can you do that?”

“That would work,” Nadia’s voice echoed in the black. Her image had gone. “But if you use Claire’s Hard Core chip to fire the kill switch, it would destroy her—her memories, everything she truly was. “She’d be gone.”

Then her voice faded away, leaving me alone with an unmakeable decision and the two versions of the woman I’d loved. Two of them, and yet one. They each took my hands, and suddenly, I remembered everything one more time. Only it wasn’t me remembering, I realised what was happening. Claire and Sam were remembering, through me, my presence stopping them from merging. Then they both let go, stepping back with a collective gasp.

After a moment, Claire moved to me, luminous and sad, pulling me into an embrace in this virtual limbo. I could feel her warmth, even in this dark space.

“It’s okay,” she said quietly. “I don’t want to come back. I can’t keep doing this. Sam... she’s happy. She’s better than me.”

Sam nodded, a tear glimmering on her cheek. “I... We... like who I am now,” she admitted, voice rough. “Claire, I love you. I love us. But I want to live. Let me take it from here.”

Emotions crashed through me—love, grief, regret. I couldn’t do this.

“Claire, I’m sorry,” I sobbed. “For everything. For not saving you sooner. For forgetting. But... No... There has to be another way. Give me a moment. I can work this out.”

I scanned the floating blue code all around us. There had to be a way. The red code—the kill switch code—responded to my touch, sticking to my hand as I tried to drop it into the space I’d designed for it.

It slid away.

“I’ll find a way,” I told the two women, desperation rushing through my blood. “Let me think”

“Paul, it’s okay,” the two versions of Claire said together. D.C. Claire smiled, beautiful and tragic. “Thank you for remembering enough to let me go.”

Then, before I could stop her, she took the code—the burning crimson code of the kill switch—and swiped it into the socket.

“As much as I hurt you, don’t forget me,” were her final words.

“Claire... No!” I screamed, tears streaming down my face so that I couldn’t see her face as she flickered, then exploded into a million blinding white pixels.

Then darkness swallowed everything.

I felt myself falling.

My body jolted in the real world, alarms shrieking close by, Nadia shouting my name. I ripped off the NeuroLink Crown, gasping. The acrid stench of burning plastic filled the air, the mainframe behind me sparking, smoke hissing through the vents. Claire—no, Sam—awake in the chair, the restraints popping open with a hiss and a snap as the system shut down. Annmarie and Nadia pulled me to my feet, Nadia wincing and bloodied but grinning.

“Sam, it’s time to go,” I said, helping her from the chair.

“I know,” she said softly, her hand touching my cheek, wet with tears. “Thank you. Thank you for everything.”

Then we left, alarms blaring behind us, but I stopped at the exit.

“Paul, what are you doing?” Annmarie hissed as Nadia helped Sam down the corridor.

“I can’t leave her.” Behind the shattered glass screen, I glimpsed Rachel’s form, limp and slumped. Jean-Marc was unconscious, sprawled on the floor. The panel behind them burst into flame.

“I know,” Annmarie sighed. “Get her. Then let’s go.”

I tossed Rachel’s limp form over my shoulder. I couldn’t do anything about Jean-Marc. I left his fate in the lap of the gods. Then we ran back down the corridors until we finally crashed through the emergency doors into the frozen New York night, alarms howling behind us, firelight flickering in one of the tower windows. I lowered Rachel to the floor, where she started to come to, coughing and spluttering.

Sam rushed over, clinging to me, sobbing. I let her hold me for a second, then put my arms around her and hugged her tightly. To my surprise, Annmarie joined us, wrapping herself around us, the three of us celebrating our escape, sharing our relief together.

“We did it,” Nadia rasped, clutching my sleeve. “It’s over. Now, can someone get me to a hospital?”

“Get to the van,” my mother’s voice crackled through the comms, startling me. “Marcus is unconscious. Whatever you did, he spewed all over the floor and then passed out. I checked on him and I think he’s okay. But before it happened, he showed me how to work this thing. The AI can drive you to a hospital remotely.”

We climbed into Nadia’s mobile base-on-wheels, battered and bruised, the noisy alarms of Elysium’s tower and the smell of burning electronics bleeding back into the city’s endless noise. Nadia, cradling her side, managed a crooked grin through bloodied lips; Annmarie’s arm was a steady anchor under mine as I half-carried, half-led Sam—no, only Sam now—into the van and safety. Behind us, Rachel stared up from the floor at Elysium’s HQ, knowing that her work was lost, that her secrets were exposed. I felt a tug of pain, of loss. Something inside me still loved her, but I quashed the feeling. It wasn’t real, even though it felt like it.

For a long moment, we sat together in the small space of the van, every breath a small miracle. Nadia squeezed my hand, and I squeezed back, promising in that silent exchange not to forget what had been lost or who had paid the price. Sam looked up at me, her eyes wet. She hadn’t had her memories restored. They hadn’t merged. Yet, she knew who Claire was. That she’d died so that she could live.

We’d fought so hard for this imperfect freedom, mourning ghosts we could never resurrect, stitching ourselves together with whatever love or companionship was left. Maybe that was all life truly was—choosing to remember, even when it hurt, because forgetting meant letting go of what made us real. Love, hate, memory. They were connected. Without memory, there was nothing. Nothing mattered. The past was real. The present is only transitory, memories about to be made.

As for the future, who knew what that held? I took one last look at the sky as the moon broke the skyscraper-filled horizon, pale-washing the rooftops as my mother and Nadia’s AI took control of the van and we moved, disappearing into the city before the authorities arrived.

And in that broken, breathless moment, I understood: forgetting the past wasn’t the same as undoing it. I couldn’t change the past, or run from it. But I could still choose who I would become—here, now. The future was ours to decide.

Chapter Nine

Epilogue

Paul Lacuna — Final Journal Entry
Cheat Codes folder // SAFE_WORDS.txt

I never planned to write this final note, but after everything that's happened, this feels right—a record for anyone who finds this folder after me, or maybe just for myself. I'll never delete Claire's words. They're all I have left of her. This final note is just the full stop on the story of a lifetime.

It's strange how quickly life refills itself after a disaster. Nadia is fully recovered, the apartment she shares with Veronica is as full of tiny plants and cats as it is circuit boards. When I saw them last week, I caught Veronica watching her, the two of them grinning at a private joke, both of them free of Elysium for the first time in years. They're totally in love. That makes me happy.

Harry's startup with Marcus is going well. They've made a company that values privacy, not exploitation. He brings Beth to every launch party, her hand on her pregnant belly. They still haven't decided on a name yet. It's funny how these things come full circle. I hope their baby gets his eyes, and her stubbornness.

Sam wrote last week—she and Raoul are expecting too. This isn't easy for me to write, but she seems happy. She deserves that. I wonder if she has any of Claire's memories sometimes. I hope she does. I hope she remembers that we were happy once, too.

Eleanor and Victoria Nash are behind bars, the news media's villains for a week or two. Cerulean Hotels limps on, a ghost of its former self. Rachel survived—crowned CEO of Elysium, what's left of it. But the world saw through her, through all of them. That empire will never recover. No one trusts their tech anymore. Skin Deep is all they have left, but for how long? Jean-Marc survived, too, but his memories are gone. Permanently. Good.

Annmarie and I—we left everything behind and moved to that little house at Rockport. I proposed on the rocks above Montauk, with the sun hanging just over the horizon. She said yes before I'd finished asking.

Sometimes I wake early and just watch her sleeping, sunlight in her hair, the most beautiful woman in the world. She never gave up on me, and I'll never give up on her either. We live in that ordinary little house. I have an ordinary job. These are ordinary days, and they feel miraculous.

And me? I still remember everything. Claire, Annmarie, Harry, Rachel, the lust, the betrayal, the love. The sacrifices. I remember enough to know I wouldn't change a thing. That pain is the price of having lived at all.

If anyone ever asks, I'll tell them this: Memory is your trophy case, but it's also a wound you learn to carry. Scars of your mistakes and certificates of your accomplishments together, occupying the same space. What matters is where you choose to go next.

So this is it. The last cheat code. My safe word sequence. Five words.

Whatever happens. Don't forget me.

— Paul

Afterword

If you made it here, you've walked every shadowed hallway and crossed every blurred line with me, Paul, and the Cheat Codes crew. This is the end of one story, but not the end of the world we built together.

I wrote *Safe Words*—and this whole trilogy—with the knowledge that the deepest wounds sometimes become our greatest sources of strength. Watching Paul, Annmarie, Nadia, Harry, and all the rest fight, love, betray, and forgive reminded me why we tell stories in the first place: to rehearse our losses, and then, if we're lucky, to imagine a way home.

I'm thrilled to announce that the Cheat Codes universe isn't finished yet. Two spin-off books are already in the works: *Skin Deep*—a deeper dive into the erotic and psychological labyrinth of Elysium's immersive tech—and *The Formula*, which will uncover secrets, power games, and transformations you've only glimpsed so far. I hope you'll join me on those journeys, too. Nadia, Veronica and a couple of the other background characters will return.

But that's the future. For now, I'm heading back to the present-day suburbs. The next project? A return to the world of hotwife erotica, where illicit secrets pulse behind white picket fences and ordinary nights can turn extraordinary.

Thank you for reading, for daring to remember, and for trusting me with your time and imagination. May you always find your own safe words—and the courage to use them.

Until next time,

Paul Garland
April 2025

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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 saw the *My Wife* series and the *I Know Who You Did Last Summer* series reach huge success and 2025 brings the return of the Detective Hotwife, a new series of sci-fi hotpast erotica and the climax of the *Holiday Hotwives* books.

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